

Restaging Place: Performativity and the camera. Parliament Square recast through social media photography

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I, Judith Brocklehurst confirm that the work presented in this thesis is my own.
Where information has been derived from other sources, I confirm that this has been indicated in the thesis.

Abstract

This practice-related study of a politically charged public place, Parliament Square, London is led by an examination of social media photographs that have been taken there and posted online. The photographs have been removed from the fast flow of social media, transposed to analogue film, slowed and analyzed. During this physical process four social activities emerge: tourism, protest, state occasion and the everyday. An investigation into each of these areas is instigated by a close examination of one related photograph. This investigation occurs theoretically and in the realm of performative sculptural, photographic and film practice.

As well as being a study of the actual place, the Square offers a public location from which to reflexively examine its virtual equivalents online. Through performative practice, my study highlights commonalities between the role of photographs, monuments and public places as methods of representing historical understandings and their democratic potential: the 'everyday' of the Square and photography. The study investigates the role of photography in the construction of place – deconstructing how tourists pose and gaze into the camera to return to the singularity of the individual experience. The enquiry continues to look at Parliament Square as a place of political protest counter to the dominant state narrative of the past and the present. It is a place where particular narratives are embodied and celebrated, often misrepresenting the complexity of the past.

The four photographs are restaged in the studio. Here they become a distorting mirror of both actual and virtual places revealing an absence that arguably occurs within all photographs. This absence might allow the viewer to relate to the subject depicted, find common ground, as well as develop a critical self-awareness and openness to the views of others.

Impact Statement

Like a photograph this thesis captures a moment in time: the explosion of social media use and its effects on actual and virtual public places. Instagram provided a source of data but also a platform for dissemination of that research, as such like social media and the technology used to access it this study has built in obsolescence. However the subject of this study is cross-disciplinary, within it I have used experimental research methods and presentation formats. Inside academia it could therefore offer starting points and insight into many different research areas, for example: photography, social media, urban design, cultural, political and social uses of technology, and heritage studies.

The research method I developed could help enhance the validity of artist practice within social science research. Particularly my presentation of processes through the use of QR tags within the text which link to online video content. This method of investigation and presentation repositions performance, film, photography and sculpture from the end result of research to integral method. The successful use of these experimental and creative methods might encourage others to push the boundaries further and also add to the debate as to how arts practice fits within academic study. Ideas and methods used in this thesis might initiate the development of experimental teaching methods such as creative workshops, performance based lectures to introduce and inspire new research methods.

Outside academe this study might influence public policy towards actual and virtual public places. Whether that be in their design: to encourage the public to become more socially and politically involved or aware. Or the inclusion of temporary or permanent art works that might provoke thought about the purpose, possibilities and value of historic urban and also virtual public spheres. Although the actual place studied is specific: Parliament Square, the ideas discussed pertaining to its use by the public and those who determine how it appears and how it might change could be applied to many similar places around the world.

This influence could occur through public dissemination of this research online, specifically on Instagram. Pushing in particular for the need for people to become more aware of the possible positive and negative uses of social media. Like a photograph this thesis will have a different impact on different people, it might at some point be dusted off and evoke nostalgia for the initial struggles for critical use of globalised social media, and how it began to become interwoven with debates surrounding actual local public places.

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Conclusions: Place restaged, cameras performed, Parliament Square recast through social media photography

This cross-disciplinary study started in 2011 when Instagram had only just been launched. At the time of writing this conclusion in 2017 it had become a global phenomenon used by millions of people to communicate with each other across national borders. Meanwhile Britain was busy attempting to reform and reposition itself as a 'sovereign' nation, outside the community offered by the European Union. It seemed at odds with this fast-changing political and technological environment to write a conclusion, especially to a study that sought to put the emphasis on process ahead of origins or finalities.²⁵⁷ As Massey emphasises, 'things' must be reimagined as processes to allow for a reconceptualization of place (Massey 2012:20). These 'conclusions' then might be reimagined as a series of linked snapshots of 'work so far' that unravel complex multiplicities rather than define singular truths.

This study has many strands; in Mitchell's terms, I have studied pictures or in this case social media photographs as a 'form of theorizing' (Mitchell 2005:6). Primarily this theorizing investigated the role of photography in the social construction of actual and virtual public places, and how the two interact. The investigation took place through the written word and also practically in the studio.

Through the processes of theorizing, deconstruction and restaging the Square has been recast, and different interlinked themes emerged. The themes span the

²⁵⁷ I am aware that this thesis like the two smartphones that have been my tools has a built in obsolescence. It deals with a fast moving durational present where apps, the Internet and the way people use them are changing at a pace. Instagram might be superseded by other apps or fragment under the weight of its use, it might be deemed too commercial by certain groups who will disband and reform on other platforms to avoid the increased advertising in what used to be a commerce free platform. I see this investigation of place and social media as ongoing. Once I have finished writing I want to spend more time in the studio processing my thoughts and many of the visual ideas that did not reach this final edit. I also want to see what reactions these fragmented restaged images receive when they are reintroduced to the flow of Instagram.

Cutting, digital film, 2015



of 'after images' unsettled the very purpose of the *Camera Obscura* and displaced the observer.

Modernity, in this case, coincides with the collapse of classical models of vision and their stable space of representations. Instead, observation is increasingly a question of equivalent sensations and stimuli that have no reference to a spatial location.²⁵⁶

Crary 1992:24

The blurring of the roles of producer and consumer, as described by Espinosa, further complicates the repositioning of the observer. If the consumer is seen as the viewer, the viewer is also drawn into being part of the production. The viewer has moved not only from a position of objective outsider to subjective sensor, but also from passive consumer to active producer. The smartphone and Instagram make the producer aware of the viewer. When taking the photograph, the producer knows that they will receive feedback as to who 'liked' it; this also influences what images might be taken and posted. When the photographs are sent out, do they cause a sensory overload? Do they control those who see them, do they alter how places are perceived and understood by others? For me, the unsettling of objectivity and the blurring between viewer and producer questions how knowledge is formed and how the world is understood. It returns me to ideas of process, social interaction and also making and seeing art as contributors to communal knowledge.

²⁵⁶ Crary's description of the breakdown and distancing that occurs between actual places depicted or seen in the 'space of representation' adds yet another facet to understanding the different interpretations of space and place.

position. For conservatives, he argues, the *Camera Obscura* is part of an 'account of ever-increasing progress toward verisimilitude in representation, in which Renaissance perspective and photography are part of the same quest for a fully objective equivalent of a "natural vision"' (ibid 1992:26).

The Cartesian interpretation of the mechanical non-human eye can be used as an argument for rationality for science and singular truth. Crary points out that the *Camera Obscura* is often deemed by 'radical historians' to be means of control: They see 'the *Camera Obscura* and cinema as bound up in a single enduring apparatus of political and social power, elaborated over several centuries, that continues to discipline and regulate the status of an observer' (ibid 1992:26). Whereas Benjamin and Espinosa, amongst others, see the camera and the photograph's revolutionary potential.

Fragmented mirror

The *Camera Obscura* was seen as an epistemological linchpin for a rational scientific understanding of, and therefore control of, the world. Writer Johann Wolfgang von Goethe and artists such as J. M. W. Turner began to shift understandings of vision as the provider of a singular regulatory truth. Crary describes a liberation of vision in the 1820s and 1830s which led to a 'repositioning of the observer': from 'outside of the fixed relations of interior/exterior presupposed by the *Camera Obscura* and into an undemarcated terrain on which the distinction between internal sensation and external signs is irrevocably blurred' (ibid 1992:24).

This liberation occurred due to coinciding factors which questioned the empirical truth of the apparatus, focusing instead on the embodied, subjective reaction of the observer. It resulted in a non-linear assessment of the discourse surrounding these technological devices and the images they produce. This narrative includes Peirce's semiotics which very clearly steers the discussion towards the possibility of rational reading of signs; it also includes Barthes' critique which emphasised the importance of individual affective understandings (pg. 55). Crary singles out Goethe's investigations of colour, experiments which concentrated on the emotional 'affect'

person holding this device in a position which, as Espinosa describes, blurs the demarcation between producer and consumer. The immediacy of taking, sharing and viewing blurs this differentiation further. Seen in this way the smartphone is part of a social relationship. It develops and changes the discourse between what can be invented, what comes on to the market and how it is used, rather than determining and controlling the behaviour of people who use it.²⁵⁵ Both Espinosa and Steyerl's thoughts could be seen to have their roots in Benjamin's *The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction* (1936), where, as Emerling states, Benjamin describes photography as inherently political: 'the shattering of tradition that reproducibility signals, whereby plurality of copies is substituted for a unique existence, offers revolutionary potential' (Emerling 2012:11).

The smartphone and its connectivity have augmented the function of the analogue camera; that does not mean it has become obsolete, or that its potential has been exhausted. However, the way people relate to photographs and to the places they see through them has been changed by the addition of the digital screen on which the newly taken photograph can immediately be viewed. For me the digital screen links the camera to the function of the *Claude Glass* and the *Camera Obscura*. This questions the position of the producer and the viewer, placing them somewhere between subject and object, a scenario which Crary describes vividly in relation to the collapse of the 'objective truth' of the *Camera Obscura* (Crary 1992:24).

The smartphone, like the analogue camera, the *Claude Glass* or the *Camera Obscura*, can be seen as sites 'at which a discursive formation intersects with material practices' (ibid 1992:31). All offer ways of framing vision, ways of understanding and representing what is seen by others through an intermediary technology. The *Camera Obscura* is the older technology; Crary warns, however, that it is dangerous to trace a linear progression linking it directly to the photographic camera. The *Camera Obscura*, he argues, is a functioning object formed by discourse, a discourse which because of the link to photography has positioned the *Camera Obscura* and the observer of images into a binary opposition which obscures a more complex

²⁵⁵ A situation which could be described as technological determinism (see pg. 124).

cheaper and therefore more widely used, thus widening the frame. I am aware that access to the technology, leisure time to use it as well as disposable income to pay for 3G contracts all influence which photographs are posted, and therefore what image of the Square is formed online. These decisions have a bearing on the way the Square is perceived. (See pg. 119 for discussion of Hall's proposal that 'heritage is a mirror' (Hall 2002:74)). I have equated these found photographs with what Steyerl describes as poor images precisely because of their capacity to cast light on those who take and look at them.²⁵⁴

Poor images present a snapshot of the affective condition of the crowd, its neurosis, paranoia, and fear, as well as its craving for intensity, fun, and distraction.

Steyerl 2009

These Instagram photographs are not only a guide to the crowd, but also to the crowd's interaction with the tools that they use. Steyerl's exploration of poor images succeeds an earlier text written by filmmaker Juan Espinosa. Writing in 1979, Espinosa describes the possibilities offered by the availability of cheap video cameras to prospective filmmakers in Cuba. In *Imperfect Cinema* (1979) Espinosa explains how the accessibility of technology democratises culture. This widening doesn't denigrate what is on the gallery walls or cinema screens; it does question it by putting the means of producing popular, accessible and interesting 'images' into many people's hands.

Popular art has always been created by the least learned sector of society, yet this "uncultured" sector has managed to conserve profoundly cultured characteristics of art. One of the most important of these is the fact that the creators are at the same time the spectators and vice versa. Between those who produce and those who consume, no sharp line of demarcation exists.

Espinosa 1979

Whereas Steyerl picks up on the affective condition of the crowd that is mirrored by the images they produce, Espinosa draws attention to the interaction between the crowd and what they produce. He singles out the development of new, cheaper technology as a major factor. Similarly the smartphone camera and screen places the

²⁵⁴ Arguably not all Instagram photographs might be classified as poor images in Steyerl's terms. She is referring to images that are gradually degraded as they travel around global networks. Yet Instagram photographs are fast moving and ubiquitous and often not treated as what might be termed rich Images on gallery walls.

and camera phones held up, the whole view is hidden, the 'pre-processed image' is preferred, only certain aspects are chosen framed and kept. Arguably smartphones mirror, distort and delimit the surroundings whether through the normalizing Instagram eye which is governed by likes, as Silverman describes, or through its internal mechanisms: the choice of filters, the framework of the system.

Unlike the *Claude Glass* the black mirror of the smartphone hides its technology; it is hard to see beneath or beyond it. Galloway describes the interface (the screen) between the different realities of virtual and actual as 'autonomous zones of activity' (Galloway 2012: vii). In his view interfaces are places in their own right. In the Square, for example, people interact with the actual location through the interface of the smartphone screen. The technology, whether phone or *Claude Glass*, places a barrier between the actual and its ideal representation. I wonder if people become lost in this interface zone: does it just provide another script to participate in, amongst many others? Is this interface one which distracts from criticality rather than provoking it? Conversely, Grosz argues that people cannot completely escape their embodied surroundings: 'This computerized or virtual space is always housed inside another space - the space of bodily dwelling. You can't be in a computer space unless you're also in another space' (Grosz 2001:24).²⁵² Watching people interact with each other and their phones in the Square is like watching a slow choreographed dance. All are moving to an invisible script.

Heritage mirror

The movements and scripts can be traced on Instagram. When photographs are taken, geo-tagged or hash-tagged, they accumulate to form personal public online archives. Like any archive they are framed and defined as much by what it holds as what it does not.²⁵³ Nonetheless, Instagram provides a less controlled, more user-generated and therefore more varied view of the Square than the Google image algorithm. The tool that has been used to produce and consume them has become

²⁵² Grosz uses the word space in an all-encompassing manner akin to Lefebvre.

²⁵³ BH has curated his Instagram account deleting photographs to tell a particular narrative and present himself in a particular way.

8. The Smartphone Mirror

Throughout this study my smartphone has played a pivotal role but has remained largely invisible and unscrutinized. It has been a provider of raw material, a creative tool in the studio, an intermediary between the public and private sphere; it allowed me to look without being seen.²⁵¹ It has the potential to be a mode of display and a political actant. However it frames, constrains and directs what can be seen and what is represented, while itself often remaining unnoticed.

Black Mirror

Standing in the Square I took out my phone with the intention of taking a photograph and caught a glimpse of the sky and the trees mirrored in the black surface. I saw an echo of the *Claude Glass*, a polished, black, slightly convex, oval mirror which was used by artists and travellers in the 18th and early 19th Century to view the landscape. It not only framed but also changed the appearance of what was captured in the pre-photographic lens, making what was viewed in it more painterly. Artists such as Gainsborough were influenced by the way landscape could be seen through the *Claude Glass* as art historians Amal Asfour and Paul Williamson describe:

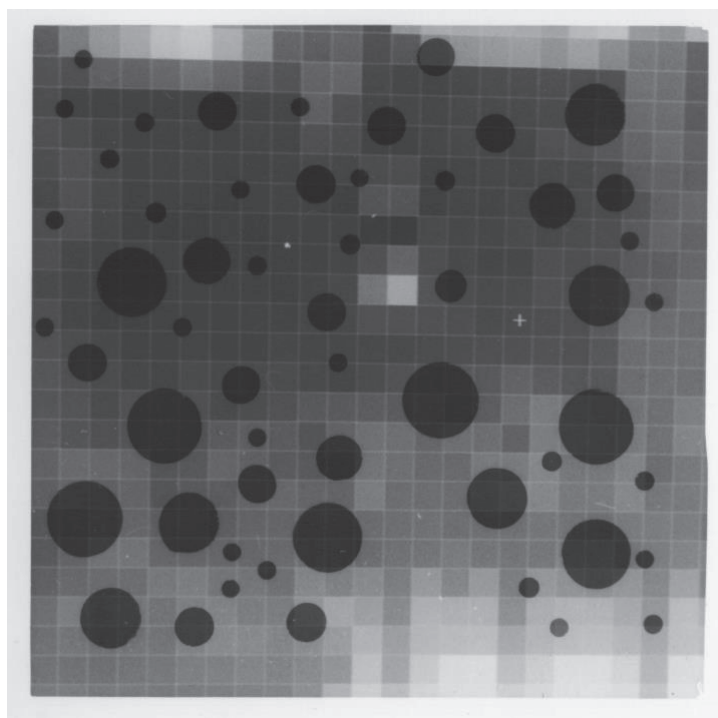
The landscape is reduced to a manageable size, placed in a frame, and spatial distance is undermined in a way that suggests the presence of an unexpected conceptual gap between the viewer and the painted scene. The *Claude Glass* diverts attention from the landscape proper to a pre-processed image; physically present in a natural environment, the sketcher looks away from the real scene to see only its reflected image.

Asfour and Williamson 1999:170

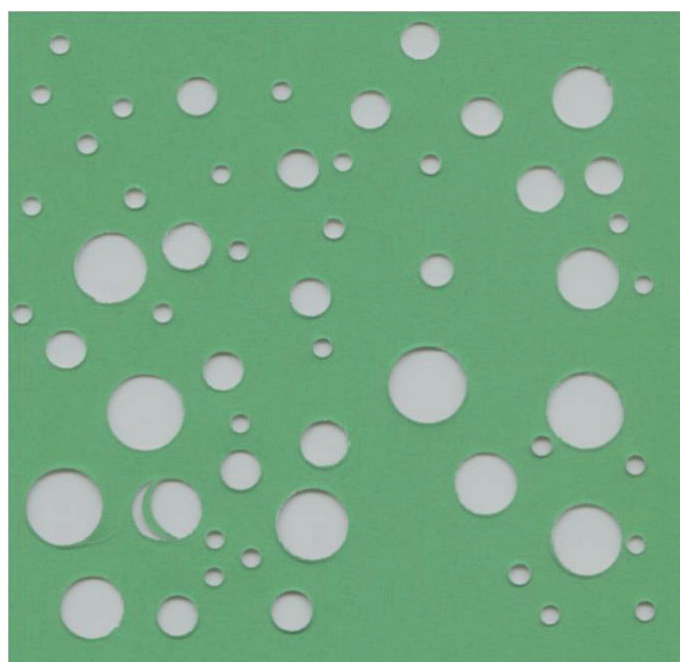
In order to view the reflected image in the glass, people, whether tourists or artists, had to face away from the view they came to see. The captured reflection was perhaps preferable to the actual unconstrained sight. The term 'black mirror', often used to describe the *Claude Glass*, has persisted to describe the smartphone. It is not only the description that has endured, the actions too are similar: backs are turned

²⁵¹ In Appendix II I look at how artists have repurposed online photographs, making it the raw material for their own ideas (see pg. 279).

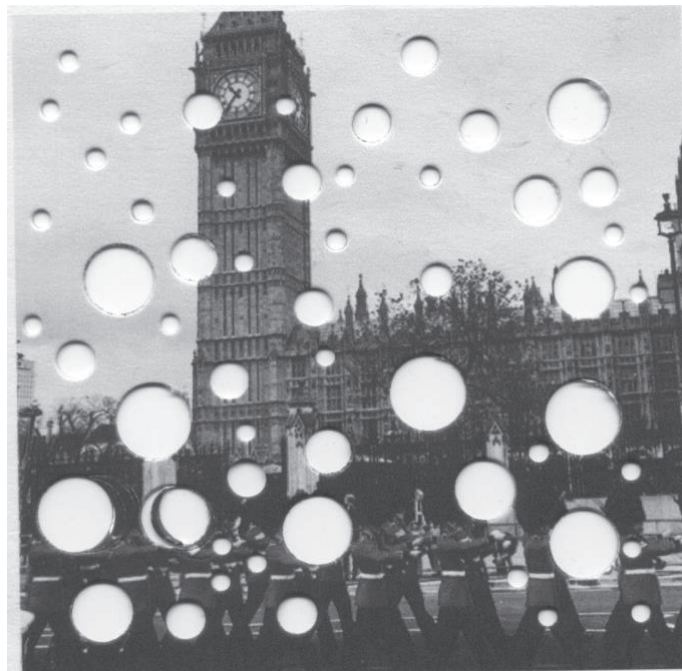
Digital Holes, analogue print, 2017



Holes, print template, 2017



Holes, digital print/collage, 2017



Analogue Holes, digital film, 2017



Control over the depiction of history and tradition in the Square has shifted between those seeking to promote the *Pax Britannica* and those maintaining the flow of traffic necessary to preserve the *Pax Capitalista*. At the time of writing there is a situation described by Howard as the *Pax Technica*, in which networked devices combine with global corporations and national governments to build a mutually secure system based on stability and predictability (ibid 2015:230). This *Pax* or control system is built by harvesting social media and other personal data which is used to instigate order and cohesion. The possibly illusory stability and predictability engendered by traditions such as The State Opening of Parliament and a belief in historical state narratives might soon be taken over by the collation of 'big data'. The ease of collating this data is increased by the escalating size and reach of the monopolies that control the Internet: Google, Amazon and Facebook.

The data is gathered from networked smartphones and computers whose users freely and/or unwittingly share this valuable information about themselves, their location, political views and monetary transactions through their online social activity. This meta-data lies invisible under the surface of the Instagram photographs that have been my guides. The photographs are capable of providing even more information than appears on their surface. The data is a raw material; it can be mined by governments and conglomerates, used to predict and manipulate behaviour. However, I wonder if the data can be mined in the sense that it can be made explosive.²⁴⁹ This would demand a knowledge of the way these systems work. Methods which are at the moment used to play the algorithms to spread fake news and create advertising revenue could also be used to raise awareness of the way this data is being exploited. If the data were to be mined in a different way personal information might be diverted away from it being used for commercial purposes or to gain political influence and redirected for the common good.²⁵⁰

²⁴⁹ Artist Fred Wilson used the word 'mining' to describe his reinterpretation of artefacts at the Maryland Historical Society in Baltimore, USA in 1993. In *Mining the Museum*, Wilson juxtaposed artefacts from the archive such as shackles used to control slaves and placed them next to silver sugar bowls normally on display. Mining the museum for artefacts and information but at the same time exploding its established didactic narratives by suggesting new ones.

²⁵⁰ This is beginning to happen: crowd-sourcing data can be used in many fields from tracking traffic congestion to medical research and climate change research.

Amin's description of a city square which returns me to the role of photography as a perpetuator and challenger of tradition but also the simplifier of historical narratives. Azoulay, as already discussed, sees archival photographs as a way of reassessing singular victor narratives of history. Sontag suggests it is 'the zeal of photography to debunk the high culture of the past transforming it from art into a cultural document' (Sontag 1979:131). I would argue that Sontag's statement could have a wider field of interpretation, where photography can also unsettle high political cultures. As sociologist Philip N. Howard maintains: 'images are powerful because they can bolster or dissolve political authority' (Howard 2015:124). The tradition of photographic representation and its role in memorializing the nation has developed parallel to the Square, changing its topography and role.²⁴⁸ Through the smartphone, contradictory histories can now be seen while physically present in the Square.

When the old Palace of Westminster burnt to the ground in 1834, a large crowd of spectators booed and jeered; brought together by the spectacle, they vocally expressed their contempt for parliament and parliamentarians. Over time different groups have gathered here for different purposes. As Hicks points out: if a space is political it will be seen as such not only by supporters of the state and the government but by the opposition. Public places, both virtual and actual, allow many views to be visible. Communities are formed in and by these places in different ways. Feelings of togetherness or shared values offered by public places are echoed online. However the digital architecture and customs of some platforms, particularly those which are interacted with through algorithms, offer a different form of community. Algorithmic communities are not based on what Bauman saw as a togetherness formed by shared but appreciated differences or the freedom of communication; but it are brought together by the online echo chamber of similar views.

²⁴⁸ Photography's role in memorializing the nation is often written about in much the same terms as monuments. Photographic historian Elizabeth Edwards, writing about *The National Photographic Record Association Archive*, describes different positions: (to paraphrase) collective memory can be understood as social memory – memory held by a specific group, sometimes though the collective is privileged over the individual reactions (Edwards 2006:54). Photographs like monuments can be seen as anchors around which different understandings, causes and social groups gather. With reference to this archive which was collated between 1897-1910 she writes: 'it was a form of holding on to the past in both its real and metaphorical roles. This was a past that was still alive in the rural areas and beneath a thin surface of modernity' (ibid 2006:55). Edwards is writing about a collection of photographs which could now be equated to Instagram. Hash-tags can be seen to form a taxonomy within the archive which memorializes people, events and places.

and disturbances. These muddled pasts suggest futures where the possibility is left open for people such as Brian Haw, Ada Wright and Jan Smuts to be valued. The idea of a speaker's corner debating area is a nod in this direction, as is the inclusion of local voices. A more inclusive approach to how the Square might develop and change could be guided by Azoulay's thoughts on how the past can become a critical guide to the present and the future.

Potential history should be understood here in the dual sense of unrealized possibilities that still motivated and directed the actions of various actors in the past, and of possibilities that may become our own and may be reactivated to guide our actions.

Azoulay 2011

The past always augments the reality of the present; how the past is depicted in the public realm determines to a certain extent what alternative futures can be imagined. If the complexities of the past become tangible, more critical awareness of the present and the futures might also emerge. Amin describes how public squares in their multiplicity do already offer a platform for other voices. I think this is enhanced by the way social media and open source information platforms like Wikipedia inform the way places can be perceived by those who watch them closely and critically. Like the Square, social media platforms such as Instagram are public places that could become sanitised and homogenised, but they are also dirty and noisy, disparate and disrespectful. Such platforms are also capable of offering a public voice and a place where communities can be formed and new grass-roots traditions can be nurtured. The future is bound up with digital technology which has already digitised the past, reproducing it as a flat achronological plane. It is as incomplete a depiction of time past as any library, museum archive or square, while offering easier access to information. The algorithmic past (which could be seen as a model of Bergson's durational present see pg. 199) offers a chance to investigate the history of a place in situ. Here, unknown statues can be searched for connections made and old possibilities reactivated.

As discussed in my Google tour of Parliament Square, a more anarchic algorithmic view is offered by the image search engine which throws together images from different sources and different times. The uneasy juxtaposition of images is closer to

camera of a phone, with crowd-sourced and archival photographs geo-cached with GPS.²⁴⁵ Yet the apps' interpretation is often lacking in political insight; users and visitors are often presented with a single narrative. Another example is the Talking Statue's project which offered the chance to listen to statues of mainly literary figures dotted around inner London.²⁴⁶ Moving away from adapting technology currently in use, the authors of the Hansard Society report speculate on how augmented reality could be used to change perceptions and use of the Square.

Elements of the real-world physical environment could be augmented by computer-generated imagery to enable people to see the past, present and future of the built environment. This technology could, for example, bring alive the development of Thorney Island, and recreate 'lost' features such as the River Tyburn and the sections of the Palaces of Westminster and Whitehall that have now vanished.²⁴⁷

Hansard Society 2011:10

In this possible future of the Square, technology could be used in the same way as the monuments have been: to tell a singular narrative that would keep social norms in place. This might be seen as helpful towards maintaining a cohesive national identity; however, this future version of the past might, like the monuments, ignore the intricacies of current society as well as the complexities of the past. Geographer Ash Amin maintains that sanitisation and simplification should not become the future of such places.

I think I prefer the noise, disorganization, and unpredictability of the ordinary contemporary square of popular protest or tolerance for diverse usages and groups, even as a basis for building citizenship. If urban renewal is about nurturing alternatives and creative potential, then part of the task is to find ways of giving voice to subaltern, excluded and marginalized citizens.

Amin 2000:234

Amin offers an alternative imagined future which involves valuing the different social processes that are part of the Square. He echoes Bauman's view that 'togetherness, far from requiring similarity ... actually *benefits* from the variety of lifestyles, ideals and knowledge' (Bauman 2012: 177). Amin and Bauman value the past for its noise

²⁴⁵ Most smartphones have very accurate Global Positioning Systems.

²⁴⁶ Talking Statues is a publicly funded project which allowed the statues to speak by connecting to a smartphone app. None of the statues in Parliament Square have been enabled to speak - maybe they would argue too much? Projects such as this do raise awareness of who these figures are, bringing them back into sight. However none of the statues are particularly controversial figures, the project remains within the monuments' consensus-forming remit and avoids tackling contentious issues.

²⁴⁷ Thorney Island was the name of the area of scrubland where Parliament now stands.

The authors of the report go on to recommend the invention of new traditions to revitalise the Square, suggesting the celebration of International Day of Democracy, World Heritage Day, or the Magna Carta anniversary. These events would be instigated not by parliament itself but by a steering group. They suggest handing over partial control to a community of users who would manage the Square more adroitly than the rather heavy-handed Greater London Authority and Westminster Council.²⁴² This is a slightly awkward attempt to wrest control of the Square from those who have traditionally held it in an attempt to make its governance more transparent. Although this report appears to advocate relinquishing control, it seems to me to be an exertion of soft power in order to sanitise the Square of its recent history of ‘eyesore’ protesters.²⁴³ Underlying many of these proposals is a desire to promote civic duty and an understanding of history that is now mediated not by statues but through modern technology. The Hansard Society recommends channelling current patterns of visitor behaviour to promote their committee-approved historical narrative of the Square.

A diverse range of smartphone applications should be developed to enable the public to engage with Parliament and the World Heritage Site from outside the building. These would enable Parliament to offer the public a broader range of information about the building, its function and history and leverage greater value from the art and archival collections.

Hansard Society 2011:10

Much of the archive is already available online; however, it is hard to navigate and to draw out particular ‘storylines’ from the mass of documented debate. As with squares, archives are precarious; Tsivopoulos’s work makes apparent that archive information can be activated in different ways (see pg. 212) and is open to (mis)interpretation. Apps such as History Pin already model this kind of interpretation of history by allowing users to overlay old photographs onto present places.²⁴⁴ The app produces hybrid photographs by combining live images from the

²⁴² Specifically the authors of the report propose a steering group: ‘In order to manage participation in the Square a steering group should be formed involving neighbouring institutions, the local authorities and user representatives. This Group should develop a protocol for light touch management of activities in the Square, incorporating concerns around noise and access as well as a code of conduct’ (Hansard 2011). There is little sign that these proposals have been acted upon in the last 6 years, since the report was published.

²⁴³ Brian Haw’s protest camp was cited as being an eyesore by politicians (in Moore 2010).

²⁴⁴ History Pin is an international, not-for-profit organisation whose purpose is to ‘connect communities with local history’ (History Pin 2017).

individualism. Social media platforms such as Instagram might be places where the nation state can be seen to be breaking down, either through the influence of commercial globalisation and mass consumerism or perhaps through delocalised customs and tribes/communities increasingly being built online. In this unstable situation the public square still offers a place to take part in traditional occasions, to share them with other people in a crowd, to be part of a community, as the photograph of the state occasion and its caption indicates.

The photograph (figure 37) shows how things, ideas, objects and people interact. As Massey writes, they are in process, always changing; reimagining things as processes allows place to be reconceptualised.²⁴⁰ Traditions and histories can be seen as part of this changing process. I wonder where these processes are taking the Square: what are its potential futures? Recently plans have been proposed to change the Square again, not physically but socially: *A Place for People - Proposals for Enhancing Visitor Engagement with Parliament's Environs* was published by the Hansard Society in 2011, in the wake of Brian Haw's contentious removal from the Square.²⁴¹ The Hansard Society's aim is in tune with the original purpose of the Square: It seeks to promote the virtues of parliamentary democracy. Their study suggests that the Square should be a place for citizenship. Conversely this suggestion could also run counter to another enacted effect of the Square which sociologist Richard Sennett describes: 'images of communal solidarity are forged in order that men can avoid dealing with each other' (Sennett 1970:34). A problem which the Hansard Society wants to resolve with, in my view, archaic solutions.

The Square should be a forum for spontaneous and organised citizenship similar in style to a Speakers' Corner. It should be a place where the great thinkers, writers, and artists of the day can give talks and lectures and engage in discussion with the public about their ideas. The Square could also on occasion be a theatre for bringing alive our democratic history: a place where key moments in the development of British democracy are dramatised.

Hansard Society 2011:8

²⁴⁰ Reimagining things as processes could be understood in Law and Latour's terms: things or non-humans are enacted; through that enactment objects, places and their meanings are constantly changing and therefore in process.

²⁴¹ The Hansard Society is very much part of the establishment it was founded in 1944 by politician Stephen Hall-King, the first subscribers were Clement Atlee and Winston Churchill. It describes itself as 'an independent, non-partisan political research and education Society' which 'believes that the health of representative democracy rests on the foundation of a strong Parliament and an informed and engaged citizenry' (Hansard Society 2017).

Parliament added a public aspect of pomp and pageantry that before had only been seen behind closed doors in the Palace of Westminster. The duty and respect that are expected of the public watching this occasion is built into the place and the event.

The Square is a place where history and national identity can be regularly reconstructed, interpreted visually and represented to the public, as historian Maiken Umbach states: 'built environments...were important media in which a sense of the past was configured and communicated' (Umbach in Hicks. 2004:28). Photographs of the Square trace how its Victorian style was modernised in the 1950s and received a gradual postcolonial makeover in the last ten years, while retaining its state intended pedagogic purpose. The traditional state ceremonies that occur in Parliament Square are intended by the governing state to perpetuate the respect and duty due to the Monarch and Parliament that are inherent to Britishness; as former MP Graham Allen explains: 'Although the Queen never gives a political ideology to the British people, she regularly expresses fundamental values for the British state. Her presence embodies the values of duty and public service' (Allen 2002:39). Pomp and ceremony is expected and embraced by parts of the population and rejected by others.²³⁸ This is perpetuated, I would argue, to engender security through cohesion and continuity. With the attempt to build and unify a nation, the past is used to build a secure future. However Journalist Mary Riddell identifies the strange imbalance that the monarchy causes in contemporary Britain: 'it is insulting that citizens who can talk to politicians without ceremony must assume a pantomime obeisance in addressing a minor royal. In an informal age, modern Britain, with its creaky ceremonial, its swan-upping, guard-changing and State Opening of Parliament, less resembles an evolving nation than a revival of HMS Pinafore' (Riddell 2002:24).²³⁹ People build their own national identity, Bauman argues: 'the institutional scaffolding capable of holding a nation together is thinkable increasingly as a do-it-yourself job' (Bauman 2012:185), eroded by globalisation and

²³⁸ Parades such as the Changing of the Guard and the State Opening of Parliament are also heavily marketed as tourist attractions.

²³⁹ 'HMS Pinafore' is a comic opera written by Gilbert and Sullivan. It was first performed in 1874. Gilbert and Sullivan's productions often offered an absurd pastiche which lampooned Victorian era values and mores.

innovation. The parliamentary decision to reject a move away from this location can arguably be seen as an example of this narrow idea of linear progression: Buckingham Palace could have offered more room to allow all of the members of parliament to sit at the same time as well as for public galleries to be larger – a different, more transparent democracy might have developed in a different place (Salmon 2009).²³⁷ Like Hobsbawm, Williams draws attention to the speed at which anything can become traditional - ‘it only takes two generations’ (op cit (1976)2014:314), yet how traditions often retain the appearance of an unchanging ancient ritual. For Williams the development of tradition is an active ongoing process that can be bent and used to suit present political contexts and can point the way to particular futures. Parliament Square fits into a pattern of such public places that were built across Europe in the late nineteenth-Century in order to promote particular national narratives. The rise of nation states relied on the promotion of ‘ethnic unity’ (Bauman 2012:169). This, as Bauman explains, meant the differentiation between state-imposed traditions and those that might be seen as holding smaller communities together.

The nation-state, after all, owed its success to the *suppression of* self-asserting communities; it fought tooth and nail against ‘parochialism’, local customs or ‘dialects’, promoting a unified language and historical memory at the expense of communal traditions.

Bauman 2012:173

Public places were being redesigned and created to display national identity. As Hobsbawm noted in *The Invention of Tradition* (1983), buildings and monuments in Wilhelmine Germany ‘were the most visible form of establishing a new interpretation of German history’ (Hobsbawm 1983:274–5). A more fragmented version of this scenario is represented in the erection of Christopher Columbus’ statue in New York, which could be seen as the Italian community seeking ownership of a founding father of the American state. In Great Britain the visual interpretation of history as centred round imperial yet democratic politicians formed part of Victorian national identity. The now traditional parade before the State Opening of

²³⁷ It is now proposed that Parliament leave the Palace of Westminster while it is renovated, causing much discussion over how the change of the design of the chamber might lead to different, less adversarial debates with many different opinions being voiced. Such a design change was rejected by Churchill after damage caused by bombing in World War II made sitting in the House of Commons almost impossible as he valued the intensity of the chamber.

which can be enacted, which in turn allow the ideals of the nation state to be represented in the Square. The tension between the two words underlies this investigation: there is constant friction between the slowly changing, largely state-determined location and the temporal social activities which occur there. Derrida's criticism of spatial power structures through the idea of *khora* might be brought back into view here. The back and forth between what is known or intelligible and what is felt or sensed might open up the ground under these structures. In this place the power of the state to instigate and guide the roles of the actants dominates and supersedes the unexpected interventions. Although these ceremonies are carefully choreographed, tensions remain. The Square, like the Palace of Westminster, was most probably designed with such state ceremonies in mind. Its layout and statues dignified the arrival of the monarch; it made the ceremony that was about to take place behind closed doors visible to the gathered public. All of the state occasions that take place here, whether royal weddings or Armistice Day march-pasts, maintain clear social divisions between participants and spectators. The photograph is taken from behind the barriers in almost the same position in the Square to that of the protest photograph (figure 25), yet the place is transformed. This occasion is far removed from carnivalesque demonstrations, ramshackle tents and spontaneous critical mass cyclists or indeed from the flows of office workers and tourists. However, the same process of visual animation of the surroundings takes place. In this situation though, the architecture and statues are not appropriated by the protesters or owned by the posing tourists, but reinforce the state's intended pedagogic purpose. This ceremony is repeated, year after year, along with many others - it has become a tradition.

The word tradition can be applied to personal rituals and repeated social habits such as taking a selfie; however, when traditions are developed and instigated by the state it is often for a specific reason. Tradition like history is a process made or carried out in the present. Although associated with the past, it is part of what forms the future. Williams defines tradition as 'a handing down of knowledge' but with a predominant sense of this activity entailing respect and duty (Williams (1976)2014:314). He warns that adherence to tradition can be used to dismiss

subtly vetoed due to the cost. In 2003 Burch predicted that Margaret Thatcher would be the next statue to arrive (Burch 2003:351). This plan is still occasionally mooted but sidelined due to fears of vandalism, masked by citing bureaucratic parliamentary rules.²³⁵ Ward-Jackson wrote, in 2011, of rumoured plans for the existing statues to be lined up in an avenue in line with the north door of Westminster Abbey, shifting emphasis away from Parliament towards the Church (Ward-Jackson 2011:189).

Monuments like photographs seek to project the past into the future. Successive governments choose particular people such as Mandela; who are picked out as much for their importance in the present as for what they are meant to project from that present for the benefit of the future.²³⁶ There is a hope that the statues and the people who choose them may play a part in forming what that future might be. These decisions made in the present face an uncertain reception and interpretation in the future. It cannot be known how they might be co-opted or subverted by future political or social contingencies, as is demonstrated by the arguments about Rhodes, Smuts and Lee. The current, ever increasing use of social media perpetuates the already substantial digital archive of the Square; it will provide a detailed body of evidence of the 'process of place', as well as platforms for campaigns for erasure, using hash-tags such as #rhodesmustfall. The erasures and additions as well as the way these monuments are animated and used by differing social groups will be well documented, providing a people's eye view of its shifting civic pedagogic purpose.

Potential or traditional futures

The title of this section 'State Occasion' is in itself an etymological and temporal contradiction; 'state' implies the stasis and solidity of a nation whereas the roots of the word 'occasion' link it to the unexpected happening or occurrence. Law destabilises the foundational idea of the nation state, arguing that it is socially enacted rather than offering an explanatory framework for a place like Parliament Square (see pg. 146). The static solidity of the statues and architecture offer scripts

²³⁵ For more details about the proposed statue of Margaret Thatcher see (Mason 2017)

²³⁶ This echoes Abbott's view of photography's role in holding onto a moment for the future (see pg. 100).

Square. By paying homage instead to those parliamentarians who abolished the slave trade, it could have served as a reminder that collective democratic action can bring about change for the common good. However, the Fountain would also stand as a reminder of a time when this practice was allowed.²³³ Instead the Fountain was moved in 1949 to the relatively unvisited Victoria Tower Gardens. It remains a monument to the white men who abolished slavery rather than a memorial to those millions who suffered and were exploited as slaves. The wealth which flowed from oppression is embodied in the infrastructure of the Square and the city, the Fountain could be a reminder of a moral duty to act differently in the world today. The Fountain stands in proximity to the statue of Emmeline Pankhurst (unveiled in 1930) in Tower Gardens which seems to have become a place where evidence of a more radical past is sidelined as an adjunct rather than the foremost political narrative. Whereas Britain's colonial past remains ingrained yet invisible in its public places and memorials.²³⁴

As statues and monuments were moved or removed, other projects that were mooted but never came to pass indicate the struggles for control over what the Square should celebrate and what meanings should be made there. The large Egyptian stone obelisk known as Cleopatra's Needle was once earmarked for the spot (in 1877); it was eventually placed on the Embankment. It is left to the imagination as to how this immense looted treasure dating from 1450 BC would have affected the connections, associations and understanding of colonial nationhood that could then have been made. The Middle Eastern politics of Lloyd-George or Churchill may have been seen in a different light with the dignified stolen stone monolith for company. At the time of its transport to London the obelisk was another symbol of British world dominance. In 1910 monarchists made a bid to wrest control of the Square from parliament when a colossal royal memorial structure was proposed after Edward VII's death. The idea was revived in 1936 in a proposed commemoration of George V (Ward-Jackson 2011: 189). More recently, a large unicorn fountain was planned for the Queen's Silver Jubilee (1977), but was

²³³ The Bristol Slavery Museum remains the only institution to be solely dedicated to examining slavery and its legacy.

²³⁴ Victoria Gardens is now the proposed site for a UK Holocaust Memorial.

point zero in order to address conflict and political decisions made at the time. Referring to the archive of photographs she built up relating to the Palestinian conflict, Azoulay discusses the need to 'reconstruct the constituent violence' of the images and the political decisions that were occurring at the time (Azoulay 2013:551). I would argue that statues and places as well as a photograph can be a point zero.

It is not sufficient for such history to criticize the existing situation. It must reconstruct the possibilities that have been violently erased and silenced in order to make them present anew at any given moment.

Azoulay 2013:553

Watching the Square and the archive of photographs that Instagram and the Internet provide could enable many points zero to be examined. Although the Square has not witnessed the level of violence and oppression as the Middle East, most of those represented are closely linked with contentious political decisions that resulted in bloodshed (see debate surrounding Lloyd-George (pg. 153) and Churchill's (pg. 179) national and international use of police and military strength). Azoulay sees photographs as catalysts which enable an examination of the fracture points in history - points where multiple futures were still possible. I wonder if there is such a thing as a point zero. Origins tend to suggest the search for an original cause, whereas I think what Azoulay is hoping to find is a moment where many causes were possible and could have led in different directions. When looking at the Square, there was always something there before it which contributes to how it is now. The absences, removals, editing that can be traced by analysing old digitised photographs or reading old guidebooks can reveal what different possible histories and therefore possible futures have been erased from the Square.

One possible point zero from which to analyse the Square and its messages could be the removal of *The Buxton Memorial Drinking Fountain*. It was described in the 1878 Baedeker guide to London as 'a handsome Gothic fountain erected in 1865 as a memorial to the distinguished men who brought about the abolition of slavery in the British dominions' (1878:173). It was not only a monument but served the practical social function of providing clean drinking water. Were the Fountain still there today it could provide a contrast to the 'Great Men' narrative that still pervades the

Artists' interventions such as these or the changing set of artworks on the Fourth Plinth in London's Trafalgar Square allow an opportunity for critique, which I would argue, is much needed in a place such as Parliament Square.²³² In the physical absence of such works in the Square the role of critical questioning could happen virtually through interventions on social media.

All the clues about these overlapping histories are visible but must be sought out: The Jewish sculptor vilified by politicians, the Indian activist making sandals for his gaoler. Nevertheless the visual triggers are there and provide a possibility for the viewer to find links across time and discrepancies in a singular establishment narrative of the Square. The ability of many visitors to use Google on a smartphone in situ might reveal some of the links that I have uncovered. Personal memories may emerge, conversations occur; photographs are sent out which, like this one (figure 37), can spatialize history making links with Accra, Cape Town, Oxford and Charlottesville. As convoluted networks between these statues appear, time is not made static by being made spatial (either in the photograph or in the Square). Spatialized or represented 'space - time', as Massey would call it, (Massey 2012:27) is dynamic and forever changing as the viewer's eye moves around it. The context evolves and changes for each viewer. Visual shortcuts and links are made that break down the sequential order of events and things; each statue and each change that has been made to the Square can be linked by different viewers, allowing different narratives to be constructed. Seen in this way, the Square can begin to escape its singular pedagogic origin.

This multiplicity has always been 'the present' of the Square but the complexities tend to get smoothed over and eroded with time. The present Square could be seen as an incomplete political and social archive; it holds a multitude of origins or potential histories as Azoulay puts it. There are many potential pasts that can be revealed in the ongoing presents. Places, like photographs, need to be 'watched' rather than statically looked at. Azoulay talks of using photographs to go back to a

²³² The Fourth Plinth was intended for an equestrian statue of William IV but remained empty for 150 years, due to a lack of funds. Since 1998 the plinth has been the site for regularly commissioned site-specific art works.

In the case of Smuts as well as the loss of reference to 20th Century global politics, the story behind the statue itself would be lost to view. Its sculptor Jacob Epstein was a controversial choice in the still largely conservative and partly anti-Semitic British political and art establishment, not only because of his religion but because his style, as this snippet of a letter to the commissioner of works sent in 1953 makes plain.

May I beg & implore you to see that his work may resemble and be a fitting representation of a very fine gentleman, instead of the grotesque, bulging, ugly statues that he (Epstein) usually makes.

Epstein National Archives File 2014

The bronze figure placed on South African granite was intended as a gesture of appreciation of colonial loyalty during World War II. It was also a signifier of Epstein's gradual acceptance into the art establishment. He had been vilified 'as a barbarian Jew, infiltrating and corrupting British art' (Brockington 2004). The opposition to his work and the juxtaposition of his own personal history with Smuts, reveals the pressures to conform to a committee-led ideal of realistic figurative representation. Later in 2006, sculptor Glynn Williams' proposal for a 'sliced' Lloyd-George was rejected; Williams was made to alter his proposal and conform to the norm of the Square and the political establishment (Ward-Jackson 2011:217). In Lefebvre's terms this could be seen to situate and differentiate Epstein's and Williams' depictions of Smuts and Lloyd-George, as well as the other statues, as tools of the state rather than a form of art that might question a dominated place - socially analytical forms of art such as Nishi's *Discovering Columbus* or Krzysztof Wodiczko's work *The Homeless Projection; A proposal for the city of New York* (1986). These are artworks that are capable of revealing and unsettling political structures. Somehow reminiscent of Abbott's ideals, (see pg. 100) Wodiczko projected photographs of homeless people of the locality onto statues in New York. For Deutsche the project linked the city's infrastructure with its policies: people made homeless by the city's corporate interests became monumentally visible.

[The project contests the] belief that monumental buildings are stable, transcendent, permanent structures containing essential, universal meanings. *The Homeless Projection* proclaims on the contrary the mutability of their language and calls attention to the changing uses to which they are put as they are continually recast in new historical circumstances and social frameworks.

just beneath this statue that an INLA car bomb killed shadow secretary of state for Northern Ireland, Airey Neave, in 1979.²³¹

Editing statues makes uncomfortable pasts less visible. Far from addressing and righting current wrongs such as racism, misogyny or inequality this can decontextualize the issues from their historical connections, making them less open to question or understanding. As seen with the contrary history of the soldiers' red coats, parliament has not always been at one with the monarchy. When a visual clue is left in place it can spark a moment of critical awareness that the Square has been constantly edited and reformed to suit the demands of the political climate of the time. Undoubtedly Smuts was a proponent of racial segregation which is what makes him unpalatable in a post-colonial world; yet the intricacies of his life and political roles that can be uncovered by just a cursory search online would be lost if his presence was removed from public view. Smuts negotiated a compromise with Gandhi in 1914 which gave the Indian population more rights in South Africa. Gandhi came to admire him as a 'politician' (with all the possible duplicity that the title might bring), giving him a pair of sandals he had made himself, possibly a symbolic way of humbling the man. Yet he also felt betrayed by him.

In a parallel to the protests surrounding Cecil Rhodes statues across Africa, a newly unveiled statue of Gandhi was met with derision in Accra, Ghana, as he is widely perceived there, as a racist. It was Gandhi's experience in prison in South Africa which formed his political ethos, yet he was also part of the colonial racial hierarchy, seeing himself as above the local black population (see Burke 2016). Smuts finally lost office because of his objection to all-out apartheid in 1948, and died soon after in 1950. In the same year that Smuts' statue was unveiled in 1956, Nelson Mandela was on trial for rebelling against the apartheid system. He was tried and found guilty, along with a group of mainly Jewish activists including Ruth First, Joe Slovo, Leon Levy and Lionel Bernstein. The media coverage led to an upsurge of anti-Semitism in South Africa, fuelling the belief that there was a Jewish, communist plot to topple the white government.

²³¹ INLA – Irish National Liberation Army – a republican splinter group of the Irish Republican Army (IRA).

iconoclastic secondary images pg. 99)



Figure 39 Goran Tomasevic (photographer), [*Saddam Hussein statue in Firdos Square*](#), Baghdad, Iraq, 2003

Figure 40 Casey Toth (photographer), [*Confederate Soldier statue in Durham*](#), North Carolina, USA, 2017

In the square many of the early statues have been repositioned – Disraeli, Palmerston and Peel were demoted from the front edge of the Square to the back in Grey Wornum’s reconfiguration, as their political influence waned.²²⁸ However Smuts would be the first removal. The statue of Oliver Cromwell which stands just out of frame of this photograph (figure 37), never quite made it into the Square. His statue is positioned in the New Palace Yard. The Statue was excluded from the Square after an initial trial period because, according to Stuart Burch writing in his PhD study of the Square, Cromwell’s ethos did not fit with the contemporaneous, imperial Victorian figures (Burch 2003:259-260).²²⁹ Cromwell who was partially responsible for the New Model Army’s formation and whose signature appears on Charles I death warrant, was and still is a divisive figure.²³⁰ In the 1890s he was seen as too controversial to be placed in the publicly accessible space, not because of his stand against the Monarchy but due to his violent campaign in Ireland (ibid 2003:20). The statue was eventually erected in 1899 just inside the railings surrounding the Palace of Westminster, looking out over the Square from the safety of a high plinth. It was

²²⁸ See pg. 297 in appendix I for a wider discussion of the impermanence of statues compared with historic photographs.

²²⁹ Stuart Burch’s is the only PhD thesis I could find that deals exclusively with Parliament Square.

²³⁰ A move was made recently by members of Parliament to have his statue removed and melted down, due to the war crimes he committed in Ireland. See the early day motion 1172 tabled by MP Tony Banks (2004). A plaster statue of Cromwell had been situated briefly in the Square as a test to see where other statues should be situated in 1871 (Ward-Jackson 2011:188).

intervened to decry the removal of statues celebrating confederate heroes in the southern states of America, in so doing he condoned the violent racists who were 'defending' the statue. Many statues honouring confederate figures were erected at a time of heightened racial tensions during the instigation and abolition of the Jim Crow laws (see Wilson 2017).²²⁷ Which brings to the fore a question that should be asked at the erection or destruction of any monument: why now? Battles for political territory and racial equality continue in America. Lee's statue became an anchor for both sides to express their views: one side was set on its removal, the other - mainly white supremacists and Neo-Nazis - violently demanding it be kept. At the point when blood is spilled in the debate about the removal of a statue, freedom of speech and security become tightly bound to the bronze figures. It might at this point be tempting to follow what Bauman signposted as a universal reaction to hide from risk-ridden complexity and remove controversial statues such as Rhodes or Lee and in so doing attempt to erase past and present pain and division. Yet this move might only serve a darker purpose to enflame the right but also to forget the hard won battles such as the civil rights movement and the end of segregation. The Mayor of Charlottesville, Mike Signer, who initially argued to keep but recontextualize the statue now believes it should be removed.

It became very clear to me that the historical meaning of this statue has been inalterably changed. It's changing every day in part because we're getting new threats on a daily basis from terrorists who see it as a lightning rod and want to come back here...people are frightened of what the statue will do to us. I think that it has become a public safety threat and that is its meaning now.

Signer in Laughland 2017

The context of these statues could be changed in order to explore the complex, painful and unresolved legacy of the civil war, slavery and ongoing racial injustice. Even long after the statues have been dragged away and melted down, the dramatic photographs that ensue such removals become symbols of regime change of ideological shifts, battles won and lost (Figure 40). (See Mitchell's discussion of

undergoing is necessary for their instruction as a race, & I hope will prepare & lead them to better things' (Lee in Thomas 1997:173). Lee's opinions can be seen in context of the era of colonialism where empire and imperialism were sometimes seen as philanthropic duty; another example of this thinking is Kipling's poem *The White Man's Burden* (1899).

²²⁷ Jim Crow laws had enforced racial segregation in schools, public transport systems, and other public buildings in the former confederate states in 1896. The laws were only finally abolished in 1964.

Leaked documents suggested the college had given way to alumni who threatened to cease donations to the college if the statue was removed (ibid 2016). Yet arguments revolving around freedom of speech as well as the under-representation of black and ethnic minority staff and students continue to swirl around the statue. If Smuts were to be edited out of the Square like a doctored photograph, this would negate the possibility to find out who he was and what role he played in the lives of Mandela, Gandhi and Churchill as well as the wider world. Campaigning for his removal returns the Square to its original political purpose of smoothing over past wrongs and awkward events by raising only certain people onto plinths (see discussion of Cromwell below).

In the same way that statues are erected, their dramatic removal can also be seen as a community-forming or unifying act. Monuments to Lenin were removed from many squares around Eastern Europe post-1989 – making a clear statement of intent to break away from communist doctrine. American troops helped local Iraqis to pull down Saddam Hussein’s statue in Firdros Square, Baghdad in 2003 (figure 39) to signal the end of his regime. Artist Stefanos Tsivopoulos in his work *Precarious Archive* (2015) highlighted the many times that the statue of US President Harry S. Truman in Athens, Greece had been toppled, vandalised, repaired and attacked again.²²⁵ The statue was seen as a symbol of political and cultural colonization, the archive of destructions traced fluctuations in Greek public opinion towards America. In America the proposal to remove the statue of General Robert E. Lee from where it has stood since 1924 led to protests and the murder of an activist by a white supremacist in Charlottesville, Virginia.²²⁶ In the aftermath President Donald Trump

²²⁵ Tsivopoulos’s archive included many documents and photographs not only of Truman’s statue. The archive was activated by different performers who changed what was on display, thus changing the narrative available from the documents.

²²⁶ Lee fought for the southern confederate states in the American civil war for the retention of slavery. In a parallel with Columbus historian Emory Thomas describes how Lee has been built up as an American hero and the patron saint of the American South (1997:13). Thomas goes on to temper this view. For me Lee’s views on slavery are incredibly provocative; it is hard to see past them and call him, as Thomas does, a ‘great man’ (1997:14). Writing to his wife in 1856 Lee makes his views clear: ‘In this enlightened age, there are few I believe, but what will acknowledge, that slavery as an institution is a moral & political evil in any Country. It is useless to expatiate on its disadvantages. I think it however a greater evil to the white man than to the black race, & while my feelings are strongly enlisted in behalf of the latter, my sympathies are more strong for the former. The blacks are immeasurably better off here than in Africa, morally, socially & physically. The painful discipline they are

aspects of the Square: Statues from different eras interact, remnants of Grey Wornum and Barry's configurations of the Square coexist and intermingle. The entirety of the Square is much more complex than the photograph: it was designed as a political place and remains so. The recent additions are meant to redress the past, adding a postcolonial global narrative. But the anomalies of the past bubble to the surface. A temporal short circuit occurs for me between the statues of South African General Jan Smuts, Nelson Mandela and Gandhi. As my eye moves between these three figures, different times and events are compressed and can be reimagined in the present. Smuts' statue was unveiled in 1956; it was seen and commented on by Mandela in 1964.²²² Further back, the junior lawyer Gandhi had been in negotiations concerning the rights of the Indian population of British Transvaal with then Colonial Secretary Smuts in 1908.²²³ Smuts was a personal friend of Churchill, as well as inextricably linked with racial segregation in South Africa. For me, Smuts is a pivotal figure in the Square in revealing contradictions and challenging accepted state versions of history, the promulgation of which the Square has always been used to display.

Past –potential absence and potential histories

Currently Smuts might be seen as the villain of the Square; moves are afoot to edit him out of this place in the wake of the row over Cecil Rhodes' statue in Oxford. Rhodes was a mining magnate turned colonial politician who used his wealth to carve out the state of Rhodesia. As part of this divisive colonial legacy, Rhodes endowed the University of Oxford with funds to provide scholarships for international students to attend the College where he had studied. The campaign to rid Oriel College of his likeness has died down with the College declining to remove the statue, on the grounds that he provokes debate and therefore awareness.²²⁴

The College believes the recent debate has underlined that the continuing presence of these historical artifacts is an important reminder of the complexity of history and of the legacies of colonialism still felt today.

²²² See Appendix I (pg. 267) for a more detailed discussion of Mandela's visit to the Square in 1964.

²²³ The British Transvaal later became part of South Africa.

²²⁴ Statues of Rhodes on African campuses, for example the University of Cape Town have been removed (in April 2015).

mix of pageantry, guns and crowd barriers creates a strange mix of celebration and domination. In Lefebvre's terms, this photograph traces trajectories of control and power: *savoir*, knowledge from above, is imposed on the people in the form of this public event. The people watching use their lived common sense or *connaissance* to live with that imposition (which also chimes with de Certeau see pg. 79).

The photographer experiencing this sight in the rain finds that the action she is involved with couldn't be more British. There seems to be a certain pride in the stoicism of waiting in the typically British rain to see the Queen and the parade. This could in Lefebvre's terms be a moment where monumental space effects a consensus (Lefebvre 1974:220). The public pageantry and show of strength promotes cohesion and creates a feeling of communal national identity which could be drawn from many factors: the pageantry, the crowd waiting patiently in the rain for the Queen. However, the caption beneath also suggests that the photograph was shared with a certain amount of self-deprecating irony or *connaissance*. The photographer is aware of the slightly ridiculous 'British' experience of standing in the pouring rain, behind the unsightly crowd barriers, for a momentary glimpse of the Queen and her guards.

As I look at the photograph the archaic dress uniforms and the modern weaponry are seen at the same time. The juxtaposition of the historical ceremonial dress is used to create a contemporary spectacular effect. It could be understood in Hobsbawm's terminology as a suspiciously modern tradition, a subtle public show of time-honoured, imperial military strength and power, masquerading behind the pomp. The complexities of the past are suppressed in order to promote a strong unified nation, echoing the description on Parliament's website. The contradiction inherent in the red jackets worn by the troops now guarding the Queen falls away. The photograph provides another hint though that the unified appearance of history in the present belies a fractured and bloody past, that could in turn question the visual purpose of the machine guns resting against those red coats.

I wonder what links can be made when I view the Square in this achronological way and what complexities might emerge. My eye makes visual links between distinct

has been reconfigured to suit particular presents as well as this attempt to understand these reconfigurations from my standpoint in 2017.

Present- temporal relationship

At this juncture I think Flusser's description of the chronological unsettling that occurs as the eye moves over the surface of a photograph might be useful to problematize the linear approach to understanding the 'history' of the Square. 'One's gaze takes in one element after another and produces temporal relationships between them. It can return to an element of the image it has already seen, and 'before' can become 'after'" (Flusser 1983:8-9). The eye moves around the Square as it does over a photograph, shifting between statues from different political eras, the grass, the pedestrian crossings, the railings. The chronology becomes muddled; events, people, times mingle and overlap, juxtapositions open up new stories. The 'multiple trajectories, a simultaneity of stories so far' (Massey 2012:24) might become more visible and question the singular linear narrative. The photograph and the Square exist in the present: they contain an accumulation of past events and actions, though far from concluded or static. They are part of space/time as Massey described it. I return to the photograph, initially to examine what is visible rather than what is known or can be found out, then try to apply the same method of 'achronological looking' to the Square.

Looking at the photograph (figure 37) again, this time with a deliberate intent to unsettle the temporal order and also the foundational linear narrative, I had been pulled into, my eye moves between the modern weapons and the red jackets, the Victorian gothic railings and the interlocking steel crowd barriers. The soldiers' black machine guns stand out against the bright red jackets and archaic bearskin hats. The first British troops to wear red coats were those of the New Model Army, set up by the Parliamentarians in 1645 to fight against Charles I during the Civil War. Now they are worn by those who guard the Queen. The hats are worn to impress; they create the illusion that the soldiers are taller and more imposing. Whether worn for ceremonies or battle, their function remains the same. The red coats draw the eye like the busses and telephone boxes in many other photographs of the Square. The

but effectively as an open-air museum for a collection of Victorian memorials' (Hicks 2015:174). Despite Grey Wornum's assertion that the Square was finished, politicians of the time retained an interest in this place as a political forum. Its pedagogic and political function began to be revived as memories of the gritty reality of war faded to be replaced by the need to commemorate heroes. However, as Hicks points out, the focus had subtly begun to change: 'In the mid-twentieth Century, not being a British politician was an asset in memorialization.' Britain was looking outwards to the Commonwealth as the last vestiges of empire fell away (ibid 2015:14). South African leader Jan Smuts, a staunch ally during the war, was the first statue to be commissioned since the First World War. Sculptor Jacob Epstein was chosen to create the statue. He was not an uncontroversial choice (see below); the statue unlike the earlier ones was paid for not by public subscription but entirely by Parliament.

After the long-disputed statue of Churchill was unveiled in 1973 there followed a long hiatus before the next few statues were unveiled.²²¹ It was to be nearly 35 years before David Lloyd-George and Nelson Mandela were added in 2007, followed by Mohandas K. Gandhi in 2015. A new version of 'Great Men' history was being written in the Square - one for the postcolonial age which questions the previous initial pedagogy of this place, yet uses the same language of statuary. Ideas of linear progression as a way of understanding place seem hard to escape. While attempting to reveal the origins of the state occasion depicted in this photograph (figure 37) and the place in which it is occurring, I have ended up tracing a single narrative, enticed by finding 'facts' that seem to add up to a causal chronology of events. Maybe a visual investigation, resulting in a spatial representation, might produce a patchwork of historical knowledge rather than a linear text. Massey quotes Laclau to pinpoint the problem that continually arises: the attempt to fix history is flawed; history is unrepresentable (2012:27). This version of the - possibly fictive - history of Parliament Square is formulated from the present. As the present is always moving on, so history is always changing. This problem can be seen in the way the Square

²²¹ The statue of Churchill proved initially controversial. His wife wished for one of the other proposals - by sculptor Oscar Nemon - to be chosen from the initial competition as she found it more sympathetic than the rather bullish depiction by Ivor Roberts-Jones (Ward-Jackson 2011:212).

amount of figurative statuary being erected throughout the land decreased significantly after 1918. In Parliament Square no more statues appeared until Jan Smuts in 1956, apart from Abraham Lincoln whose statue had already been planned pre-1914 and was unveiled in 1920. The *Cenotaph* (1919) up the road in Whitehall became the national focus. It was placed in the middle of Whitehall, and became a central point of informal national mourning after 1919. The clean abstract lines, a symbolic grave of the humble unnamed soldier, became a psychological stumbling block (Edkins 2003:66 and 108) for politicians rather than a celebration of them. Then again, as writer Alan Bennett makes clear in his screenplay for the film *History Boys* (2006), national memory can be swayed and focused away from the reasons why wars take place, diverted from examination of political failure to focus on the sentimental commemoration of the fallen (Bennett 2006).²¹⁹

The Square was changed physically by the material needs of the Second World War. The railings and ornate lampposts were removed and melted down for munitions, the statues of 'Great Men' thus released from the pen. The world had changed around the Square. Despite grand plans in 1949 to pedestrianize it, when architect George Grey Wornum submitted final renovation plans in 1950 they were more modest. His request for new uniform plinths for all the statues to bring them into line with his minimal deco-classical terraces was rebuffed (Ward-Jackson 2011:189). Even without the identical plinths local Conservative MP Harold Webbe described the reconstruction as 'terrifically modern and shockingly restless in its asymmetry (ibid 2011:189).²²⁰ Grey Wornum was adamant that after his intervention (and the addition of one more statue, that of Winston Churchill with whom he had consulted upon its positioning, see pg. 297) the Square was complete. No more statues were to be added, as he didn't want the Square to fill up like a graveyard (ibid 2011:208). This was an indication of how quickly the Square and those represented in it had become obsolete in its pedagogic, imperialistic and political function (see pg. 271). Grey Wornum was looking at the Square in an aesthetic light, not as part of an ongoing rewriting of history. 'It was no longer regarded as a temple to Parliament

²¹⁹ The scene around the war memorial in which the boys quote from Larkin's poem *MCMXIV* takes place in the film and not in the play which preceded it.

²²⁰ Grey Wornum was working at a time when much of the city was still being rebuilt after heavy war damage.



Figure 38 Anon (postcard), *Benjamin Disraeli statue*, 19th April probably 1903 or 1904 ²¹⁸

Underpinning the creation of the Square is another process which encompasses history, tradition and nation-building: that of the politicization of place. Over the period of the Square's first 100 years, what was slum housing became part of the establishment. The dark web of streets - a dangerous place that allowed the individual to remain hidden or anonymous and that had once been what could be described as lawless but free - was replaced by a new restrictive, yet apparently safer public area. The new Square was created by the use of railings, planting and new road layout. However it was the depiction of politicians in bronze, raised up above the head height of the public, that made this a charged political place. The suggested narrative that Square offered was expectant of particular reactions: ones of dignified respect for politicians and politics in general and the societal values that they represented.

It was not the end of Empire but the First World War which began to change the way the Square was seen. Arguably the intended pedagogy began to backfire. The credibility of 'Great Men' lay shattered in the trenches (see Hicks 2016:166). The

²¹⁸ The statue appears to be headless in this photograph. According to the person who posted it on photo sharing platform flickr, this was a problem that occurred during the development of the photograph rather than the depiction of an actual event. There is no evidence that the statues were vandalised during this time. As Hicks writes: 'Monuments in the urban landscape were cared for as carefully as they had been chosen. It was important that the shrine to great parliamentarians be kept in a fit condition for veneration' (Hicks 2015:171). Footage of the unofficial laying of flowers can be seen on a Pathé News reel shot in 1916.

Canning is the most obvious example of the link to imperial visual ideals and ideology. He is depicted in classical robes, indicating the connection that the designers of the Square and behind them the ruling classes of the time were seeking to cement in the public mind. The British Empire was to be associated with Roman and Greek Empires through public statuary. In so doing, they sought to link the strength of these figureheads with a wider ancient Imperial ideology. The Empire was to be understood as a benevolent force keeping the *Pax Britannica* across the world, building infrastructure and educating the 'natives', as had the *Pax Romana* had before it. The statues play a role in the construction of the edifice of Empire and its *Pax* which has little to do with peace and more to do with the exertion of power. 'Parliamentary politicians were the heroes of the late Victorian era' (ibid 2015: 169). The commemoration of anyone other than royalty in the form of a statue was at this time still a radical novelty (Ward-Jackson 2011: xxxv). Placing these well-known 'Great Men' of Empire on plinths ²¹⁷ in the newly reconfigured public square transformed the site from an open garden to a sacred site for political veneration. As Hicks makes clear: 'for the Victorians, to commemorate Parliament outdoors was to sanctify the British political ideal' (op cit 2015:169). As is currently the case with Nelson Mandela, some figures were more revered and visibly celebrated than others. Disraeli for example lived on in the public imagination, perhaps because he was favoured by Queen Victoria or because he was the most recent of those depicted to die. His death was commemorated on its anniversary by wreaths of primroses, his favourite flowers, being laid at the statue's feet not only by the right-leaning Primrose League, but also sent by Queen Victoria herself (figure 38).

²¹⁷ Until modernity all statues were placed on plinths, see pg. 117 footnote 125 for discussion of the role of plinths, with reference to Krauss's text *Sculpture in the Expanded Field* (1979).

Politicians were seen as offering strong individual leadership in this sphere rather than an abstract ideology.

The decision as to which monuments were to be displayed or commissioned was long argued over by the Commissioner of Works, William Cowper, in consultation with Edward Barry and the Memorials Committee. In the end it was decided that this place was to be reserved for politicians in order to laud the activities of recent political importance; there were to be no monarchs, engineers, soldiers or poets in the Square.²¹³ Hicks describes the Square as a 'visual representation of the 'Great Men' theory of history and explicitly intended to be so by the politicians who have decorated it' (Hicks 2015:165).²¹⁴ The initial headcount of statues was limited to five, all of them former Prime Ministers. Four of which were Victorian: Robert Peel, Benjamin Disraeli, Earl of Derby, Lord Palmerston; one George Canning, Georgian: all were erected in the 1880s.²¹⁵ The Square could be said to have reached a level of 'completion' in 1883 when the last of the Victorian statesmen's statues, that of Disraeli, was erected.²¹⁶ At the time Lord Elcho described the positioning of the new statues inside the Square's decorative railings as 'like sheep into a pen' (Ward-Jackson 2011:188). The intended dignity of the statues was an invitation for satire from the very beginning.

The Victorian politicians who commissioned Barry to lay out the Square and arrange the statues within it, wanted to use it for a very specific purpose. As Hicks explains, his views echoing those of Griswold who described monuments as a species of pedagogy:

It served a pedagogic function by providing exemplars of great lives for the public to observe; it served a political function (somewhat overlooked by architectural and art historians) as an outdoor temple to Parliament; and it served an imperial function by echoing antiquity. Perhaps most obviously, these memorials reflected the growing significance of 'great lives' in the culture of the nation.

Hicks 2015:168

²¹³ Isambard Kingdom Brunel had been one of the suggested subjects to be monumentalised.

²¹⁴ The term 'Great Men' theory of history was developed by writer Thomas Carlyle, who believed that it is heroic leaders who determine historic events (Carlyle 1841:21).

²¹⁵ Canning's statue was first erected in 1832 inside the Palace yard; it was then moved to the Square although not to the position it currently occupies.

²¹⁶ The Square was again described as complete in by George Grey Wornum 1950 (2011:208).

Parliament in 1605. The Vice-Chamberlain is held hostage by the Monarch to ensure their safe return. The Monarch arrives through their own entrance at the base of Big Ben and is robed in a chamber where the death warrant for Charles I (1649) hangs prominently on the wall.²¹¹ These acts emphasise the past tensions between the monarchy and parliament. The conflicts are currently defused by the carefully orchestrated version of this symbol of 'unity', which shows a glorified simplification of a complex messy past.

The public aspect of this event - the Monarchs' procession from Buckingham Palace to the Palace of Westminster, accompanied by troops in ceremonial garb - only began in 1852. Queen Victoria was the first Monarch to take part in the procession, and the first to enter the New Palace of Westminster. At that time there was a relatively empty area in front of this new grand palace to parliamentary democracy. The 'Garden Square' had been created after slums had been cleared and the land planted from 1806. It had not yet been co-opted by Parliament and aggrandized and imbued with political purpose. In 1867 Edward Barry (Charles Barry's son) was commissioned by parliament to design and commission statues in the newly named 'Parliament Square'. The statues were intrinsic to the intended purpose of the place, as the extensive research of Westminster's public sculpture carried out by art historian Philip Ward-Jackson reveals: Parliament Square 'from the first ... was designed as a showplace for statuary, and in particular for monuments to statesmen paid for by public subscription' (Ward-Jackson 2011:187). Political historian Geoffrey Hicks clarifies Parliament Square's particularity, describing it as a 'rare and useful example of a British outdoor space deliberately designed to exalt parliamentary politics' (Hicks 2015:165).²¹² The Square's origins are deeply embedded within Victorian political culture and values, as historian Angus Hawkins describes: 'politics was the public life of the community' (Hawkins 2015:3); that public life 'most Victorians viewed ... as a historically informed sphere of moral conduct' (ibid 2015:4).

²¹¹ Charles I was beheaded in 1649. According to the High Court of Justice in passing sentence, he had: 'traitorously and maliciously levied war against the present Parliament, and the people therein represented' (in Manganiello 2004:543).

²¹² Hicks uses the word space in this context whereas I would use place to denote a specific location.

including chapels and assembly rooms as well as what was originally a royal residence. It was largely destroyed by fire in 1834; only Westminster Hall and a few other buildings were saved from the blaze. King William IV offered the London seat of the monarchy, Buckingham Palace, as a replacement but his proposal was rejected by Parliament. Historian Philip Salmon links the wish to remain on the original site of the first Parliament in 1295 with a certain historic sentimentality and a belief in the politics of place. The decision to stay put was in his opinion a way of maintaining links with past events (Salmon 2009). After much debate about what style this new building should take, Neo-classicism was ruled out due to its association with republicanism and revolt.²⁰⁹ A competition was announced which specifically called for the style of the design to be either Gothic or Elizabethan. Charles Barry and Augustus Pugin's Victorian Gothic design for the 'New Palace of Westminster' was chosen to set this sense of pride in history into solid stone; the palace was finally completed in 1853.²¹⁰ The choice of this gothic revival style could in architectural terms be seen as conservative as it relied heavily on medieval perpendicular architecture. It was, however, also linked with religious nonconformist thought. Barry's design was chosen because it was in harmony with buildings that had survived the fire. This visual link emphasises that security in the purpose of Parliament was to be found in links to the past, on this site and in the embodiment of gothic architecture.

The New Palace was designed specifically for the State Opening. Separate entrances were built for the Monarch, the Commoners and the Lords. According to Parliament's official website, the State Opening is a 'symbolic reminder of the unity of Parliament's three parts: the Sovereign; the House of Lords; and the House of Commons' (2016). This current accord was born out of conflicts which are now marked by staged events within the ceremony. A complex series of actions unfold, each one linked to an historic event: The cellars are searched for gunpowder in memory of the failed plot to blow up the Monarch at the State Opening of

²⁰⁹ An example of the neo-classical architectural style is The White House in Washington (completed in 1800). See: Parliament's official website (2017), Rebuilding the Palace.

²¹⁰ Barry worked predominantly in a neo-classical style and recruited Pugin to add the gothic element. Neither lived to see the completed building.

begins in the shifting present in order to delve into the past without certainty or fixity. I am aware that I cannot know everything that there is to know about this occasion or the history of the Square - as Williams maintains, a large part of 'history' is the fictive 'story' (Williams (1976)2014:314).

Past - the process of history or failing to avoid chronology

Deleuze proposes that the past does not remain static because of the flux of the present. European philosophy scholar James Williams explains Deleuze's reasoning: 'no settled history could lay claim to the past... History necessarily changes the past, because the past only exists through processes in the present that make the past a changing event in the present' (ibid 2011:19). When this position is combined with Massey's belief that places are also in a state of constant becoming, it seems important to be aware of the dangers of a teleological reading of the past from the seeming finality of the present.

With this hazard in mind I examine the possible origins of 'The State Opening of Parliament', the occasion that has been captured in this photograph (figure 37). Like other official occasions that occur in Parliament Square - the marching of veterans on Armistice Day, royal weddings or state funeral processions -, 'The State Opening of Parliament' derives its form from the past although its contemporary function may well have altered. The past is often manipulated to suit present needs, as historian Eric Hobsbawm points out: 'Nothing appears more ancient, and linked to an immemorial past, than the pageantry which surrounds British monarchy in its public ceremonial manifestations.' However, those "'traditions" which appear or claim to be old are often quite recent in origin and sometimes invented' (Hobsbawm 1983:1). The monarch has officially opened each new parliamentary session on this site for over 500 years. The structure of the occasion has evolved and changed, drawing together a hotchpotch of customs that refer to different historical and political situations. The occasion could be seen as an echo of the old Palace of Westminster itself which was an odd assembly of buildings from different eras

than 'land', Abbott's photographs of *Changing New York* or the continuing resonance of the photograph of Ada Wright prone on the pavement in Parliament Square. Arguably, the influence of photography has increased now that the technology used to capture photographs is also the technology used to disseminate and view other people's photographs. The virtually stored photographs are traces of multiple trajectories through actual places. They provide small insights into ongoing durations. The photographs themselves have their own trajectories, reaching out into space and time with unknown results. As Emerling describes, a photograph can trace how places change, but they are always in some way 'holed' or incomplete.

Images possess a radical untimeliness: thus their ability to haunt, which stems not from historicity but from their ability to trace a geography through the life of a culture. This geography is 'interleaved' and 'holed'; comprised of places of passage and forgetting.

Emerling 2012:15

This photograph (figure 37), offers a moment to examine certain trajectories back and forth in time, opening up what Azoulay calls 'potential histories' (Azoulay 2013:551) as well as imagined possible futures which might emerge as part of the processes that are ongoing in this place. Defining history and traditions as processes chimes with Massey and Lefebvre's view of how places continue to change over time. These processes are visible in this photograph; they are interlinked and work with each other contiguously.

To reiterate, this study is also a process which involves representing places theoretically and visually. Massey is concerned that representation can deprive 'space' of its dynamism (Massey 2012:21). She uses the word 'representation' to mean conceptualised or a written-down version of space; whereas I want to expand this term to look at photography and Instagram, as well as the place that the photograph depicts. However, I want to avoid stasis. Looking at any photograph presents the viewer with the representation of a moment in the past, which could be seen as a flattening static spatialization. Watcher becomes a more appropriate stance: it allows photographs to become a method of understanding the past in the present. Watching them offers a method in which a place and its history can be interpreted and reinterpreted over time. Photographs can then be seen as dynamic actants, actively involved in shaping the present and the future. This investigation

Photographs can be seen to be ‘cut out and keep’ static, ‘spatialized instances’ with which people try to keep hold of the passing present. Massey calls for a reappraisal of the assumption that by representing or spatializing time it is made static and considered ‘closed, immobile quantifiable and pertaining to the world of representation, in contrast to the flow, passage and unrepresentability of time’ (discussed in Ross 2012:105). To begin to address ‘dualistic opposition’ between time and space that has persisted since Bergson and Deleuze, Massey emphasises that ‘a reimagination of things as processes is necessary for the reconceptualization of places’ (Massey 2012:20). Massey brings space and time or, as she puts it, geography and history together to be able to consider them together as ‘space-time’ (ibid 2012:27).²⁰⁸ This is ‘the dimension of multiple trajectories, a simultaneity of stories so far. Space is the dimension of a multiplicity of durations’ (ibid 2012:24). Even though the photograph appears to make time static and spatial, the photograph itself keeps moving and changing in meaning through time. The moment captured in the photograph is already in the past; however, every time I look at this photograph both it and I myself have subtly changed. This makes sense of Azoulay’s call to watch which repositions the viewer and the photograph into a dynamic field. The virtual stock of photographs geo-tagged to Parliament Square could be part of this reimagining and reconceptualising of space and time. The photographs themselves can be re-evaluated, in Massey’s terms, not as spatially fixed slices of time but ongoing processes at work in the world; they could be seen as traces of multiple trajectories and durations which chimes with Derrida’s formulation of hauntology.

The photograph (figure 37) leads me to examine the Square and the people in it as part of a whole ongoing ‘process of becoming’ (Massey in Zhou 2014:13). I would argue that photography is a constituent in this process. Photography and photographs have followed paintings, etchings and drawings in influencing the way a place is perceived. These visual representations trace the changes, they are capable of both revealing a political process and being part of it - whether it be Gainsborough’s *Mr and Mrs Andrews* defining the rural scene as a ‘landscape’ rather

²⁰⁸ See pg. 23 for Massey’s explanation of her preference for the term space rather than place.

The photograph that informs this chapter is the most recent one of the four that I chose to be my guides to Parliament Square. The caption underneath reads: 'Nothing could be more British than watching the State Opening of Parliament in the pouring rain'. It shows the Queen's Household Cavalry dressed in red ceremonial jackets marching past the Houses of Parliament, taking part in an occasion which predates the Square. The photograph (figure 37) allowed me to look back from the present and the way these traditions are upheld and depicted now, to the Square's role in Imperial nation building. It also opened up questions as to what the possible futures of this public place might be, unsettling ideas of a progression from its pedagogic origins.

Durational present

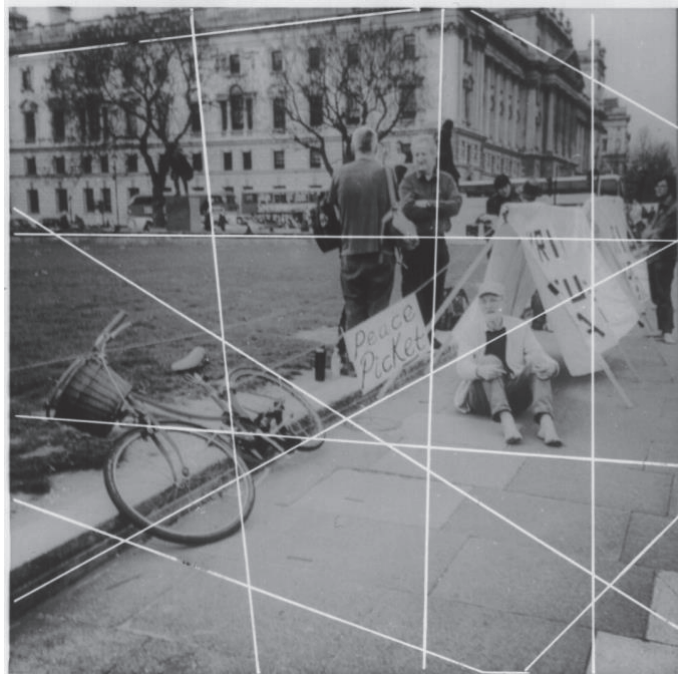
The photograph (figure 37) offers a connection to the past, not only to when it was taken in Parliament Square on May 18th, 2016, but also further back in time. The immediate glossy surface of the photographs can be excavated to examine how the event it depicts and the place it occurs in came into being. This photographic plane can be looked at as an archaeological site, its topography bears traces of history, tradition, politics and state that came together at the moment this photograph was taken. It has already been swept into the past, yet I am looking at the photograph or watching it in the present. The moment it was taken has gone, leaving this apparently static representation of a pin-point in time behind. In the model of time conceived of by philosopher Henri Bergson and further developed by philosopher Giles Deleuze, the present is 'durational', forever moving, leaving the ever increasing past growing out beneath it. Photography theorist Damian Sutton describes the difficulty involved in understanding, analysing or representing the durational flux of the present: 'It is much harder to capture and measure the continuous process of change...In effect when we measure time's passing we spatialize duration, creating 'cut out and keep' images that we can compare in order to conceive of change' (Sutton 2008:89). Sutton's description could refer to photography in general and more specifically to Instagram.

7. State Occasion

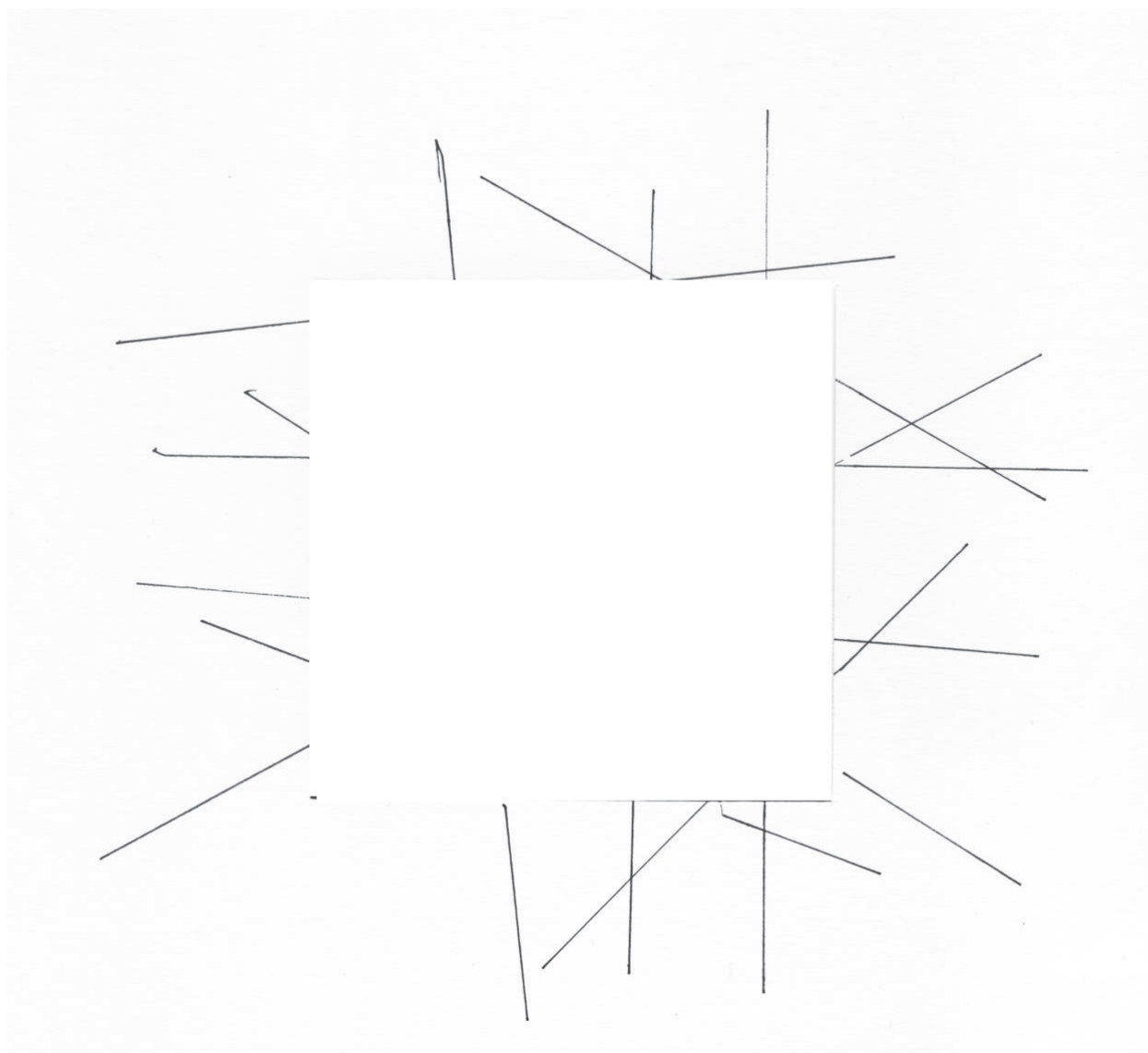


Figure 37 Anon, *State Occasion*, found Instagram photograph, 2016

Invisible Lines, analogue print, 2017



Invisible Lines, template, 2017



Boundaries, digital film, 2015



passed between actual and virtual places, as it gathered ideas and became a relational space in itself.

I wonder if there is always an element of what could be called *khora* in each photograph: an emptiness within it that allows it to become a vessel for the viewers to inhabit it with their own ideas about what they are seeing, to place themselves within it. I would argue that there is an absence and a fluidity of meaning in all photographs that allows space for many different viewers to find resonances with their own lives. Once they find that place, a non-objectifying relationship with 'others' might be possible. This civic negotiation starts in the way the viewers or watchers relate to the protagonists and realise that there is not one way of looking at a photograph and the ideas that emerge, but many.

Derrida referred to photography as *skiagraphia* meaning shadow writing - the absence of light is what leaves a trace and makes the marks on the paper.²⁰⁷ The word trace is used by Derrida to describe a situation much like Heidegger's 'invisible shadow'. Trace connotes an absence that remains uncannily present. 'The trace is not a presence but is rather the simulacrum of a presence that dislocates, displaces, and refers beyond itself' (Derrida 1973:156). Expanding on his idea of 'the trace', Derrida formulated the word hauntology, which I think applies to the situation I have found myself in. Derrida derived the term by combining the words and the meaning of haunting and ontology - (the nature of being). Hauntology encapsulates his questioning of 'Being' as not always entailing presence. Derrida used this concept to examine the legacy of Marxism, exploring the idea that the present and the future are haunted by possibilities of what could have been, akin to Dickens's Christmas ghosts. As journalist Andrew Gallix describes, there exists a 'nostalgia for lost futures' (Gallix 2011) - a longing for things that could have been (see pg. 279).

The photograph is a thing that exists in the world; it has an ontology, yet it is also defined by an absence. Hauntology also has a spatial as well as temporal aspect: what is outside the frame, haunts or affects what is in it. Reversing Berger's idea that the event depicted expands outwards, events could be seen to crowd inwards from outside the frame to affect what is seen. In the studio I took the photograph (figure 25) apart, cut it up, pieced it together with other photographs, folded, turned and spliced it. I am left with a photograph that has been changed by these processes, abstracted, detoured with photographs from different places and different times. Boundaries have been dissolved as the photograph has spiralled out to touch on many issues and raised many new questions about the way people depict public places and behave in them. The right to protest and be visible is contrasted with uncaring mechanised hypervisibility. Throughout the exploration of this photograph I have attempted to trace the complex relationship between protest, technology and public places. I have watched and changed the trajectory of the photograph as it

²⁰⁷ Emerling discusses Derrida's description with reference to Fox-Talbot's description 'shadow writing' (Emerling 2012:41).

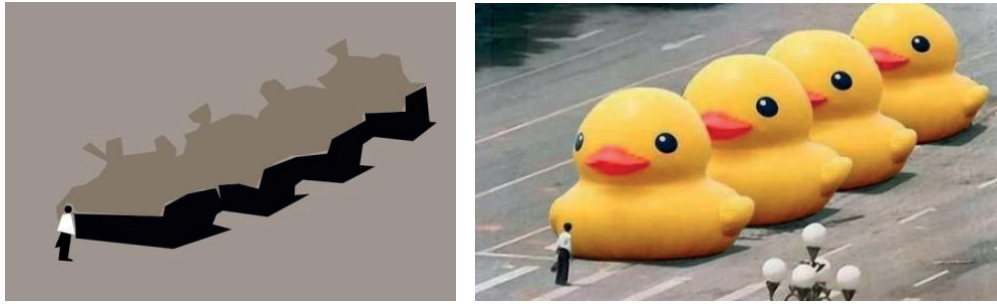


Figure 35 Jeff Widener, *Tiananmen Square protests*, 1989

Figure 36 Anon, *Reconstruction of the 'Tank man' photograph*, (date unknown)

Photographs of the protests in Tiananmen Square, Beijing in 1989, for example, are banned (figure 35). The famous photograph of a single man in front of four tanks has been reconstructed in different, sometimes absurd ways in an attempt to evade the censors and communicate that this event happened at all (figure 36).²⁰⁶ However the awareness of the absence of such information may provoke people to act as much if not more than the glut of photographs that may dull the senses and which the viewers then feel they can do little or nothing about. In this situation of visual overload viewers may be shocked into inaction; they may also be unaware of the restrictions that are in place due to their own misperception of their freedoms.

Absence and presence

In examining one specific photograph (figure 25) I have ended up looking at what is not there, what is no longer visible, what is absent or beyond the frame. Having started with the concrete, the pavement and the buildings, I have ended with the invisible. Tangible traces left by absence of light, people, times past, indicates that photographs are, as Berger states, 'an expression of absence' and part of the process of photography.

A photograph, while recording what has been seen, always and by its nature refers to what is not seen.

Berger 2013(1967):20

²⁰⁶ Tiananmen Square has been scrubbed clean of all reference to the protests of 1989, while a memorial to Jan Palach is situated in a prominent part of Wenceslas Square in Prague. The student committed self-immolation in 1969 as a protest against the Soviet invasion of Czechoslovakia. (For further discussion of censorship in China see Kaiman 2013).

Azoulay advises that photographs need to be ‘watched’ rather than looked at. Watching implies that it will change and alter in time and space. The process does not end at the digital click of the shutter or the publication/sharing of the photograph. The photograph continues outwards from the event, gathering more viewers and more meaning. Here Azoulay’s ideas move close to Butler’s and Berger’s: ‘the language in which photography deals is the language of events. All its references are external to itself. Hence the continuum’ (Berger (1967)2013:20). The photograph offers a place to gather multiple views and to link external ideas; all those seeing it are joined together, allowing a space for ‘civic negotiation’ (Azoulay 2008:16).²⁰⁴ In the context of the public realm, whether virtual or actual, photography offers an indivisible, ongoing space that allows for discussion. For Azoulay watching photographs offer the possibility of learning a new skill of citizenship that is not related to nations but to a duty to each other (op cit 2008:16). Arguably, the disturbing photographs that Haw brought to Parliament Square as part of his protest challenged visitors to think about the meanings that the monuments suggest and to ask themselves: Is it acceptable to monumentalise a political system that advocates the protection of one country by aerial bombardment of another?²⁰⁵ Even if viewers of disturbing political photographs choose not to act, they are in a position to make a choice; they are exposed to information that can be constructed into knowledge. The possibility of choice contrasts with other places, for example in totalitarian regimes such as China where mass and social media are tightly controlled.

²⁰⁴ Azoulay’s use of the term space here is akin to Wearing and Wearing’s definition. It is used to describe the social dynamic created between those pictured and those viewing a photograph which can become a ‘space of political relations’ (Azoulay 2008:16).

²⁰⁵ Protesters affiliated to Haw camped on the empty plinth before the Lloyd George’s statue was installed in 2007 to draw attention to his controversial policy of bombing the ‘niggers’ in the Middle East (In Seymour 2010). Thus bringing historical actions, policies and attitudes into direct relationship with contemporaneous policies and strategic drone strikes.

difference between being visible and the effect of being seen. The aesthetic power of many of these photographs is seductive but arguably they rarely galvanize the viewer to act.²⁰²

In an attempt to address indifference and inaction Azoulay proposes a different way of looking at photographs. She describes photography as a space of 'political relations' (Azoulay 2008:12) a view which is capable of setting all participants in photography on an equal footing removing the need for the viewers to reach a common objectifying understanding of the subject.²⁰³ Instead Azoulay attempts to set the photograph free: 'every photograph belongs to no one'. The viewer 'can become not only its addressee but its addresser, one who can produce meaning for it and disseminate this meaning further' (ibid 2008:14). Azoulay pushes the process of photography beyond the relationship between the photographer and the subject to include the viewer instigating a 'civil contract'. Wilkinson interprets Azoulay's concept as a bond which is activated 'through the imprinting of an image that is always the product of an encounter, but an encounter that is without a single author, and cannot generate a single narrative for a single person exclusively' (Wilkinson 2015). This stance alters the hierarchy of the photograph; by putting the viewer on an equal footing with the subject they become involved and responsible. Azoulay introduces the word 'contract' to avoid terms such as empathy, shame, pity or compassion as 'organizers of the gaze' (op cit 2008:17).

When and where the subject of the photograph is a person who has suffered some form of injury, a viewing of the photograph that reconstructs the photographic situation and allows a reading of the injury inflicted on others becomes a civic skill, not an exercise in aesthetic appreciation.

²⁰² The effect a single photograph can have politically and socially is a problematic area. Photographs are often credited with inciting action or even changing the course of history. For example, the photograph of Phan Thi Kim Phuc called *The Terror of War* (1972), otherwise known as *Napalm Girl*, was taken by Nick Ut after a South Vietnamese ARVN napalm strike. The photograph shows her running from her village, naked and badly burnt. This photograph is often cited as an image that changed public opinion in America and even hastened the end of the Vietnam War. According to journalist W. Joseph Campbell this is a myth; he argues cogently that, firstly, public opinion had already turned against the war and that, secondly, the war did not end for another three years (Campbell 2017:132). When this photograph *The Terror of War* was deleted from a Norwegian newspaper's Facebook page in 2016, due to Facebook's nudity laws, the photograph took on yet another meaning and role. Editor-in-chief Espen Egil Hansen addressed Facebook: 'I am upset, disappointed – well, in fact even afraid – of what you are about to do to a mainstay of our democratic society' (Hansen in Harding, Levin and Wong 2016). In this case the photograph had an effect and drew attention to Facebook's sweeping censorship algorithms. It is though hard to measure the galvanizing effects that photographs have; they undoubtedly do raise awareness and emotion which can lead to action and changes perception.

²⁰³ Azoulay's use of the word space in the context of a photograph chimes with Flusser (see pg. 136).

may look but they do not necessarily see; and if they do not see they do not understand or act. Butler is concerned that individuals and nations have developed a way of not seeing: 'this 'not seeing' in the midst of seeing, this 'not seeing' that is the condition of seeing, became the visual norm, a norm that has been a national norm, one conducted by the photographic frame in the scene of torture' (Butler in Wilkinson 2015). Butler discusses these issues with regard to photographs of torture taken by the American service personnel who perpetrated abuse on inmates in Abu Ghraib.²⁰¹ Has this condition of 'not seeing' come into being because of an overload of horrifying photographs that has resulted in all viewers becoming battle-hardened? Writer Jayne Wilkinson considers that photography and the inherent framing is part of the problem that allows people not to see. 'Butler thus identifies that photographic meaning and power are embedded in photographic processes, not only in photographic objects. Because frames delimit what is perceivable, what is understandable as a grievable life' (Wilkinson 2015). New boundaries emerge, the frame delimits what is known about the subject and their lives and also what the viewers feel they can do. The camera seems to remove the photographer and the viewer from involvement. The divisions arise as soon as the camera is lifted and pointed; the reasons for taking the photograph may have been aesthetic, political, empathetic or antagonistic. But as Barthes comments, indifference is always a possible reaction to a photograph (Barthes(1980)2000:27).

The main problem is, as political philosopher Jodi Dean points out, that there is a disparity between an issue becoming visible and people caring or taking action. 'All sorts of horrible political processes are perfectly transparent today. The problem is that people don't seem to mind, that they are so enthralled by transparency that they have lost the will to fight' (Dean 2002: 174). For me, distance and absence are inherent in photography. I wonder if this results in a general dissociation of the viewer from what is depicted, that they always have to overcome? Photographs posted by Royce and Bridle and the ones shown in the Square by Haw, amongst many others, raise awareness of many worldwide problems and injustices. There is a

²⁰¹ American service personnel documented torture and inhumane treatment of prisoners on their mobile phones in Abu Ghraib prison, Iraq, in 2003. Eventually these images were used as evidence to prosecute the soldiers involved.

Instagram is built on the idea of photogeneity and spectacle; it urges caution, however, when posting photographs of 'newsworthy events'. Even so searching certain hash-tags on Instagram can expose, in an instant, a stream of photographs very similar to those that Haw displayed. #freepalestine reveals a photograph of a dead baby shot through the heart, #syriawarcrimes a child's body under rubble. Posting these photographs as a form of protest on Instagram is done with similar intention to Haw. Placing them in the public realm makes these harrowing occurrences visible to a wider audience and in so doing tries to gather public support to stop them. However, the aim to shock or shame into action is often met with the same bewildered inertia that Berger describes. In this virtual public place photographs can be reported to the controllers of the site. They are sometimes removed if people find them offensive but in general it leaves the discretion in the hands or eyes of those using the site. People have to make a conscious decision to actively search for these photographs online, or follow the people who might post them, whereas in the Square Haw and his photographs were interrupting the everyday life of those passing through. Instagram urges caution to its users treading a fine line between censorship and freedom.

Be thoughtful when posting newsworthy events.

We understand that many people use Instagram to share important and newsworthy events. Some of these issues can involve graphic images. Because so many different people and age groups use Instagram, we may remove videos of intense, graphic violence to make sure Instagram stays appropriate for everyone.

We understand that people often share this kind of content to condemn or raise awareness. If you do share content for these reasons, we encourage you to caption your photo with a warning about graphic violence. Sharing graphic images for sadistic pleasure or to glorify violence is never allowed.

Instagram help page 2017

The question of the threshold between offense and political openness brings me back to Sontag's dichotomy between fascination with the spectacle and call to become involved. Visibility however does not guarantee action or change. People

complex process systematically limits the diversity of voices online and in many cases suppresses certain kinds of speech' (Ochigame and Holston 2016).

To realize this and to act accordingly is the only effective way of responding to what the photograph shows.

Berger (1967)2013:33

Photographs of suffering and conflict, serve to depoliticize the viewer and remove them from responsibility which he argues is evidence of the 'general human condition' (ibid (1967)2013:33). It could be argued that Haw's attempt to change policy and end UK involvement in destructive conflicts failed. Yet his persistent presence can be seen as a triumph for free speech; it allowed him to voice his individual standpoint for as long as he physically could, even when his camp was deemed an eyesore and his pleas were largely ignored.

However, the immediacy of personal multiple eyewitness photographs taken by amateurs that report on and witness 'live revolutions' and conflicts around the world, can be seen as a positive force. It does still set social media apart from mass media because it is accessible - it is interactive, formed by its participants. Viewers have to be aware that not only photographs can be duplicitous but also the sites in which they are seen.

Hence it is not surprising that struggles for visibility have come to assume such significance in our societies today. Mediated visibility is not just a vehicle through which aspects of social and political life are brought to the attention of others: it has become a principal means by which social and political struggles are carried out.

Thompson 2005:49

Sociologist John B. Thompson considers that the visual aspect of protest is now the main way in which people engage in such activity. People have access to all of these photographs through the technology that they carry with them everyday. Google Streetview 2008 shows Haw defiant on the pavement: the large photograph of the child's bandaged head is blotted out by facial recognition technology. The generic technology masked the face to preserve anonymity. This blotting out is a reminder of the automatic algorithmic censor which adds another controlling factor to what is visible online.²⁰⁰

²⁰⁰ Researcher of politics and computing Rodrigo Ochigame and professor of anthropology James Holston highlight how algorithms can become proxies for human censors: 'In the algorithmic control of information there are no clearly identifiable censors or explicit acts of censorship. The filtering is automated and inconspicuous, with a tangled chain of actors (computer scientists, lines of code, private corporations and user preferences). This

the reasoning behind the photograph. The gaze into the lens implies some kind of relationship with the camera and the photographer. The denial of the gaze, whether by actively looking away or being unaware of the camera, leaves the viewers implicated. It might be that those pictured do not want to be looked at or objectified by the camera in this situation. Or they are so involved in the moment that they do not see the camera. The viewer looks but those depicted don't look back. The camera, as Tagg described, becomes more like a weapon as its violent, aggressive hunting 'script' comes to the fore. The viewers of the hunted or those exposed to unwanted visibility are placed firmly in the position of the voyeur.

Haw, as part of his protest, chose to display disturbing photographs of children in an attempt to stop British military involvement. Viewers of the photographs are put in the position of being a voyeur of someone else's pain which is represented in a way that, in Sontag's words, 'gives mixed signals. Stop this, it urges. But it also exclaims, what a spectacle' (Sontag 2003:68). The ethics of showing these photographs are complex. Viewers looking at them in Great Britain live in a democratic country; a democracy however that keeps invading other countries and dropping bombs on its civilians. By looking at these disturbing photographs the viewer is also invading the privacy of the children shown and their families. As Sontag states, maybe the only people who should look at such photographs are those who are in a position to do something about it (ibid 2003:37). Haw was trying to do something about the situation. He used his location opposite Parliament to show these photographs to politicians who were in a position to change policy, possibly justifying his use of photographs of injured children to do so. However, Berger suggests that photographs of agony accuse everybody and nobody. Viewers are caught between their personal inability to act and help the people caught up in the horror depicted in the photograph, and their powerlessness within the political system where they are unable to intervene and stop the causes of such agony.

Confrontation with a photographed moment of agony can mask a far more urgent confrontation... The next step should be for us to confront our own lack of political freedom. In the political systems as they exist we have no legal opportunity of effectively influencing the conduct of wars waged in our name.

head makes the viewers feel some kind of affection for him, the Ada Wright photograph might cause them to reassess the historical and political depiction of Churchill as the epitome of 'the British bulldog spirit'. They might think again about his prime position opposite Parliament: was he a brave defender of the realm, a misogynist, a brutal home secretary? The network of photographs and their attached narratives reveal he was a mix of all these things. A greyer, more tangled version of historical events emerges, mediated through the build-up of photographs that can be found linked to this place online.

Viewer and viewed

The Instagram photograph of protesters (figure 25) fits into a wide set of networks, both virtual and actual. It coexists in different contexts and forms, it links with other protest photographs in other squares and with older events in the same location. It sits within a flow of miscellaneous tourists' photographs that are staking their own claim on the different possible interpretations of this site. In Latourian terms the photograph offers different social roles from which different meanings can develop each time it is enacted. The photograph is constantly capable of changing its significance and provoking new understandings of this and other places. However in all of these contexts questions particularly pertaining to the position of the viewer remain: What is the viewer's response to a photograph? Does looking make the viewer complicit as they enter a relationship that brings them into the scene and makes them part of the 'image event' (Roberts 2014:161)? At what point do they identify with the people or the subject? Can the photograph change their political views, does it draw them into crossing the lines depicted or can they remain removed, surveilling the scene from a distance?

What is noticeable about the many photographs of protests found online is that most of those pictured, unlike the main protagonist of this photograph (figure 25), do not look into the camera. The denial of the gaze can signify non-complicity in the process of photography, possibly an implicit acknowledgement that the meanings made from a photograph can be treacherous. Those depicted are far removed from the posing tourists who have a preconceived involvement with the composition and

exclusion zone around Parliament, which happens to run through the Tate.¹⁹⁸ Writer on philosophy Sinéad Murphy argues that in the context of the gallery the protest became defused and robbed of its political power. Murphy equates the tolerance shown in letting Haw stay in the Square, which she argues strengthened liberal democracy, with the way the art world functions. Murphy's arguments chime with Lefebvre's opinion that protests are tolerated to maintain the *status quo* (see pg. 28). The art world, she argues, 'operates primarily as mode of control' (Murphy 2012:4); the permissive art world acts as a 'kettle' to 'physically and psychologically contain a growing population of allegedly "free thinkers"' (ibid 2012:5).¹⁹⁹ Wallinger's representation of Haw's camp could, however, also be a measure of the iconic power of Haw's protest.

In reaction to the transformation of his protest into art, Haw handed out maps to Tate visitors in order to guide them back to the original in Parliament Square. Wallinger sees his work as a form of praise and appreciation and memorialization of Haw's political ideals, now wiped from the Square by changes in the law which in itself could be seen as a legal enshrinement of his protest. One is 'real' and one is staged. For me, Wallinger's recontextualisation of Haw's protest, unlike Nishi's work with Columbus, does not question Haw's protest or his particular visual political language; it somehow hollows it of meaning. Aesthetics of protest can be powerful as in the case of Ada Wright. They can also mislead and detract from an issue. I wonder if this is what occurs when any protest is captured and made permanent and more aesthetically powerful by a photograph?

Powerful aesthetic protest photographs can, when seen in the context of the Square, change the meanings people make there. For me, the curious photograph of the tent (figure 25) - which is somehow a more authentic re-enactment of Haw's protest than Wallinger's art - has already revealed the capacity of photographs to unsettle an accepted view or understanding of an actual place. The photographs of Haw and suffragette Ada Wright seem to haunt the Square. If the piece of grass on Churchill's

¹⁹⁸ The zone in which no unauthorised demonstrations are allowed to take place.

¹⁹⁹ Kettle is a term used by protesters and police to describe a situation in which protesters are contained in a small area, often for a long period of time. It is a technique often used to defuse protests.



Figure 34 Anon (Reuters), [May Day Protest](#), 2000

Whereas the photograph of Churchill's statue with a grass punk hair cut (figure 34) might well be seen as such. It creates a visual juxtaposition which subverts not only the 'sacred grass of England' but changes Churchill's role, co-opting him to the side of the protesters. Similar to the damaged canvas of the *Rokeby Venus*, the secondary image created through iconoclasm (even if only temporary) is politically powerful and can be used to bolster dissenting political positions.

The photograph was circulated around the world, publicizing the protesters' cause and at the same time the brand of 'Cool Britannia', democracy, free speech or shock at the iconoclasm (on the front page of *The Telegraph*).¹⁹⁷ The photograph of Churchill catches the eye; viewers are drawn to it by its visual strength. The incongruity of the grass Mohican on his head seems to only add to his bullish expression.

Photographs are a representation of an event, a way of keeping hold of it in a miniature two-dimensional form. Whereas artist Mark Wallinger's representation of Haw's protest encampment involved a life-size restaging within the Tate's Duveen Galleries titled *State Britain* (2007) which could be seen to turn Haw's tents, banners and photographs into art. The representation of the protest was legal and part of the art establishment. The artwork was displayed along the exact line of the mile wide

¹⁹⁷ The term Cool Britannia came to prominence in the early 1990s due to the resurgence in the pop and fashion industry. It was often used in reference to New Labour's election victory in 1997.

potent places deliberately to be photogenic and to capture attention leads me to question the event, the political cause, and the photograph's (figure 25) authenticity or veracity. Journalist and lecturer Paolo Gerbaudo describes the often premeditated and 'organised' nature of staged protest photographs that function almost like (urban) scenographies designed for the display of collective dissent (in Kluitenberg 2015:3). An example of this might be Greenpeace's air pollution campaign where activists fitted gas masks to many of London's statues and monuments (figure 33). The aesthetic of protest photographs may often be exciting and dynamic, they captivate the eye, but I wonder if they are capable of drawing the viewer in and involving them in the cause, especially if the viewer suspects the photographs were designed to do so?



Figure 33 Chris Ratcliffe (Greenpeace), *Greenpeace air pollution awareness campaign*, 2016

At what point do photographs become staged, can they be staged merely by the framing of the camera's lens? The composition of the photograph (figure 25), depicting the makeshift tent with its incongruent group gathered around it, feels slightly staged to me. The protagonists are aware of the photographer, they are partially complicit with her, allowing her to take the photograph. It is undramatic, not quite what Roberts might describe as an 'Image Event': a photograph whether staged or spontaneous which captures, distils and conveys the atmosphere of the protest (Roberts 2014:161).

revolution will not be televised (1971).¹⁹⁴ Scott-Heron's song rails against the mainstream media and its capacity to lull people into inaction through their belief that everything will be made better by adherence to the consumerist doctrine. The lyrics make clear: mass media is not to be trusted, as it will not show what is really happening. 'The revolution is live', happening on the streets. The use of this quote in reference to the 'Anonymous' selfie takers brings social media into the same bracket as mainstream media.¹⁹⁵ It is capable of being a disempowering distraction from the actual live purpose of the protest. On the other hand, the selfie can be a political statement which transforms a 'banal activity into a citizen act, an active performance of political identity' (Aziz 2017:27). Part of the strength of the act of taking a political selfie, Aziz argues, involves showing your face and identity which makes this particular act stronger.

The 'Anonymous selfie' indicates the seductive nature of the technology, the social pressures of sharing and the perceived need to curate a public self-image. It also brings to light that social media is drawing ever-closer to mass media as a source of information and a way of making sense of what is happening in the world. The smartphone has put the general public into the position of reporters. News is now gathered in the form of phone photographs and Twitter sound bites, the reliance on social media to provide news is also a factor in the rise of 'Fake News'.¹⁹⁶

With the suspicion that some photographs may be engineered to gain attention, the viewer needs to exercise even more caution when looking at photographs of protests. Roberts states that 'we now live in a pictorial age in which publicity is gained through photographs and representations. Political activists can therefore stage image events and articulate their political standpoint to others through media spectacles' (Roberts 2014:161). Roberts' proposal that events are put on in politically

¹⁹⁴ The song was built on a phrase that was coined during the civil rights movement in the early 1970s.

¹⁹⁵ Activists in the Occupy Movement also used social media to rally support for their cause. Professor of media communications Christian Fuchs interviewed many activists to understand their relationship to social media platforms they were using. He found that most were aware of the contradictory character of social media 'as both tools of domination and tools of struggle and that social media use is connected to power struggles' (Fuchs 2014:70).

¹⁹⁶ Fake news has been accused of weaponizing social media, organisations such as Facebook and the BBC are now becoming aware of the need to educate people how to spot such items, thus safeguarding their own status as news providers - BBC or a community service - Facebook (see Waters 2017).

Staged and real



Figure 32 Anon, *Anonymous Selfie*, 2015

Attempts to control people through surveillance can be thwarted in both actual and virtual places by hiding one's identity. Anonymity can be protected on Instagram through the use of pseudonyms; faces can be shielded by masks or hands. Out in the Square, protesters associated with 'Anonymous' attempt to occupy Parliament Square every 5th November wearing Guy Fawkes masks. With phones in hand some of these protesters take selfies to promote their own participation, probably leaving the bona-fide hackers at home on their computers (figure 32). Stopping to pose for an 'Anonymous' selfie could be seen to change the protesters' cause from an anti-capitalist protest to social media self-promotion which adheres firmly to the rules and social norms of the social media mainstream.

The caption under the photograph reads: 'The revolution will not be televised as people are too busy taking selfies'. This plays on Gil Scott-Heron's lyrics for *The*

it or appear in it. Self-vigilance may involve appearing to bide by the rules of both actual and virtual places. On the other hand, self-vigilance might result in people deciding not to use this form of media, a self-imposed virtual form of social exclusion or self-censorship which leaves them unseen.

There is a place on the Internet that allows its users to remain invisible - a place governed by its own laws. It was set up to allow people freedom to communicate without being traceable to a location or an identity. Originally coded by the US navy to keep their communications secure, 'the dark web' became a great aid to the instigators of the 'Arab Spring' amongst others. It allowed activists to agitate and organise demonstrations in public arenas such as Tahrir Square, without risk of governmental persecution. Virtual invisibility allowed public dissent to become visible. This virtual place can be used to avoid censorship and to evade arrest for political activism; it can also offer a platform for criminal activity, the supply of drugs, arms and pornography. There is a symbiotic relationship between the architecture/coded design and social behaviour in virtual places as there is in the actual city. In Lefebvre's terms the dark web is a socially constructed place just like anywhere else. Those rules and constructs are changed by the way people use it: The dark web is also the home of hackers, such as 'Anonymous', who bring together the roles of police, protesters and online activists.¹⁹³ The hackers are part of a loose affiliation that takes the form of a decentralised web from which different splinter groups emerge. Their general ethos was summed up by journalist Carole Cadwalladr who compared the group's decentralized structure to that of al- Qaeda, 'If you believe in Anonymous, and call yourself Anonymous, you are Anonymous' (Cadwalladr 2012). From their untraceable virtual base camp they 'occupy' and disrupt government and commercial sites, leaking potentially incriminating documents. They take down Islamic extremists' websites and reveal personal details of their fighters. Hackers are not unlike the protesters: they animate and repurpose the virtual architecture of the web for their own causes.

¹⁹³ The dark web also provides cover for state-sponsored hackers such as 'Fancy Bears' group which has close links to the Russian government.

The freedoms that Instagram provides allow Bridle and Roye to create a place in which they can draw attention to their issues and causes. They draw a gathering of followers who question the place in which they show their own images and push out the boundaries of what the platform can be used for. Arguably most people stay on the Internet-equivalent of the pavement and cross by the crossings. They remain only partially aware of the control that is exerted over them or which they impose on themselves in these virtual places.¹⁹¹ However, as sociologist John Michael Roberts describes, digital places have their own decentralised network of social norms (see pg. 129). The social control does not come from one central source; in a digital echo of Foucault he argues that this 'new form of control no longer relies on governing individuals in localities through one central point of command in the guise of the state... control operates through codes and databases that anticipate and indeed socially construct the behaviour of discreet populations' (Roberts 2014:117). In my opinion a power flow of normative behaviour can be seen on Instagram as hash-tags and trendsetting users set the visual and social tone.

Instagrammers belong overwhelmingly to a certain demographic.¹⁹² They follow certain codes; their photographs are affected by socially constructed norms, even in the event of a protest. The camera could be seen as an instigator of self-control, as Barthes noted when he controlled himself in advance of a photograph being taken, the possible publication of images continues that process. The knowledge that a wider possibly unknown audience will see the photograph probably has an effect on what photographs are taken and how people perform in front of the lens. Although visual control of the network may be decentralised, the awareness of being publicly visible through a photograph has an effect: 'the panopticon', as feminist author Sally Munt puts it, 'imposes self vigilance' (Munt 1995:115) (see pg 37 footnote 36). This self-vigilance is learnt from the realization that photographs have other possible roles and can tell other narratives, independent of those intended by those who took

¹⁹¹ There was a move to boycott Instagram after the new owners Facebook tried to alter the rules of ownership of images in 2012.

¹⁹² 58% of users are aged between 18 to 29, 33% between 30-49. 39% of photographs are taken in urban settings and there is a relatively even use across income and education brackets. See 'Social Media Demographics to Inform a Better Segmentation Strategy' (York 2017).

describes these photographs as ‘before images’ (Bridle 2015): a photograph which pre-empted the event which befell it.¹⁸⁹

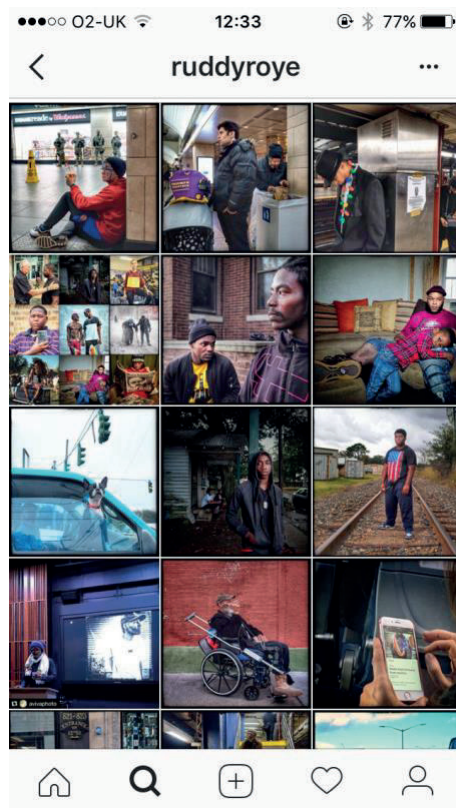


Figure 30 Ruddy Roye, *When Living is a Protest*, Instagram photograph series, 2016



Figure 31 James Bridle, *Dronestagram*, 2014

Bridle’s subversion of both Google and Instagram turns the technology to view itself. His work raises awareness of the photographs that remain hidden and the dangers of becoming inured to photographs of death and destruction. His interventions on Instagram make apparent the omniscience of the technology. For me, his work questions whether surveillance makes the general population feel safe, or if people even care that they are being watched; it makes me wary of the military capabilities of the phone in my pocket.¹⁹⁰

¹⁸⁹ ‘Before Images’ could be seen as akin to apparently mundane CCTV images of events taken shortly before a crime occurs.

¹⁹⁰ An example of this is the strange lack of awareness or fear apparent in police behaviour during some of the most recent filmed shootings of stop and search subjects in America. Many of these crimes were perpetrated by white officers on black subjects. This indifference might suggest that some people no longer fear the repercussions from images of their own misdeeds.

act of protesting online – are forms of performative democracy and exercise freedoms that bring a ‘space of appearance’ into being in actual and virtual places. Being visible and being heard are vital parts of an open political life of a country. Without public questioning, policies are carried out unchallenged or unnoticed.

Other methods of protest emerge that subvert or appropriate the online social space that can be created on Instagram; photographs may slow that flow and create a space for conversation. Following in the tradition of social realist photography, activist photographer Ruddy Roye takes photographs of homeless and deprived people on the New York streets and documents his conversations with them (figure 30).¹⁸⁶ Arguably the photographs that he posts create an ongoing virtual version of ‘Occupy’ on Instagram.¹⁸⁷

Roye’s photographs keep deprivation and the precarity of the individual visible in the increasingly glossy commercial place that Instagram is fast becoming. His photographs also provoke debate amongst very different members of society, a discussion that probably would not take place in public on the street. Artist James Bridle’s project ‘Dronestagram’ (figure 31) subverts and appropriates Instagram to reveal the underlying nature of the technology that powers it. Bridle reveals that the network of satellite communication that allows users to access photographs from around the world is also employed by the military for drone strikes and surveillance. That gives me an uncanny chill when I look at the many frivolous photographs that are shared.¹⁸⁸ Bridle plotted each media report of drone strikes by the US and its allies through Google Earth, posting the geo-located satellite photographs online. These are photographs from before the strike; they immediately bring to mind the photographs used to show the apparent precision of such bombing raids. Bridle

¹⁸⁶ This is a broad field of photographers and styles that could encompass people such as Diane Arbus’s investigations of the everyday strangeness of people on the streets or more abstract architectural images of Berenice Abbot.

¹⁸⁷ Roye is aware of the fine line he treads between what could be seen as voyeuristic depiction of vulnerable people living on the street and his own position as a photographer making money and gaining recognition through his work. By placing emphasis on his conversations, which are attached to the online posts, the text and comments that follow relocate the subject of the photograph to the position of co-producer of their depiction.

¹⁸⁸ This uncanny feeling returns me to Derrida’s description of the groundlessness underneath societal power structures (see pg. 145).

places. It offers another 'space of appearance' - a place where, for example, police brutality can be exposed and politicians called to account or sexual harassment challenged. It is a place where issues and ideologies can be aired in public. As with the London Liberties, different areas of the web are controlled by different rules, some more permissive than others. These distinct sites and communities are defined by rules that govern how they look visually and how people behave there. For example highly surveilled activist groups often use Snapchat because of its impermanence.¹⁸⁴ Snapchat could be seen as closest to Hakim Bey's TAZ as it is so fleeting. Its multimedia messages disappear after a few seconds. Such transience seems to encourage an increase in boundary-breaking use, both political and personal.¹⁸⁵

What occurs on social media which doesn't necessarily happen in live streaming is the extension of the political dialogue from the streets to the virtual public sphere. On Instagram publics gather virtually around a photograph in the same way that they gather around an issue visually represented by a tent or a banner or a monument in actual places. Underneath the photographs, dialogues ensue and 'likes' accrue. Communication and action in actual and virtual places interweave and interact. Butler links protesting directly to the act of online communication: 'what bodies are doing on the street when they are demonstrating is linked fundamentally to what communication devices and technologies are doing when they report on what is happening in the street' (Butler 2011). Protesters move through the fabric of the Internet in a similar way as they do through public squares, to act and make their cause public. This movement online is often simultaneous with the movement on the street. Cultural media theorist Eric Kluitenberg describes how acts of communication add to and strengthen the physical protest: 'Nomadic fluidity of activist operations across any and all media that makes them resilient and efficacious' (Kluitenberg 2015). Both acts - protesting and documenting/sharing the

¹⁸⁴ Snapchat is an encrypted message platform. Messages disappear after a short period; appropriately the app symbol is a ghost.

¹⁸⁵ Snapchat has been used by teenagers under the age of consent to send nude pictures of themselves to other users (see Gayle 2015). This can result in both those sending and receiving the images being placed on the sex offenders' register. Snapchat amongst other encrypted social media platforms has been used by Islamic extremist groups to recruit but also promote their radical causes (Majeed 2016:268).

The street scenes become politically potent only when and if we have a visual and audible version of the scene communicated in live time so that the media does not merely report the scene, but is part of the scene and the action; indeed, the media *is* the scene or the space in its extended and replicable visual and audible dimensions.

Butler 2011

Digital media researcher Fatima Aziz describes how participants in the Freedom Marches held in Pakistan in 2014 used social media to amplify their involvement. 'Performance of citizenship through selfies ... becomes a dialogical gesture, transforming rally participants/photographers into claimants addressing their appeal to other protesters as well as government officials and foreign media' (Aziz 2017:23).¹⁸¹ Aziz goes on to describe how the use of Instagram can be transformative. During the act of protesting it can be used in the manner Butler suggests as 'a public broadcasting platform', but also as a form of 'visual signature' which when shared '*en masse* can challenge power' (ibid 2017:23).¹⁸² The photograph found on Instagram as Batchen argues is *power*, it is an interlocutor part of a flow between the event and the viewers. It is a node of communication about the place and the cause that the protesters support. I think social media photography platforms are capable of performing a similar role as actual public places – they can become a place in which the reach and the political potency of an event can be extended in time and space.

Virtual and actual

Instagram is a regulated, commercial, virtual public realm which relies on its users to generate content but also to self-police and report abuses of its rules: what Peel might recognise as consensual policing. However censorship is still an issue here.¹⁸³ The public sphere created by the users of social media is interwoven with actual

¹⁸¹ The Azadi or Freedom March was held between August and December 2014. It was organised by Imran Khan's TPI opposition party to protest about vote rigging. The aim was to walk with a rolling and ever changing group of participants from Lahore to Islamabad.

¹⁸² Aziz mentions that those posting selfies at the march were mainly male due to the self-policing actions of female users of social media, who instead posted 'indoor selfies' wearing badges of support to avoid parental stricture. Taking selfies as a family group had begun to be more acceptable and also political (Aziz 2017: 24).

¹⁸³ Censorship on Instagram relies on people reporting photographs they find distasteful or exploitative. There are general guidelines for unacceptable content which include picturing menstrual blood and female nipples (male ones are seemingly inoffensive).

another form of policing, the photograph a form of evidence placed in the judicious eye of the public through newspapers, social media or the courts (see Trottier 2015:214). The camera like the police can be a deterrent, a reason to conform.

Pointing the camera becomes a method of exerting control. Professor of art history John Tagg describes the camera and the law in equal terms:

What engages me then is not that the law and photography are *exposed* as the docile instruments of an exterior power but, on the contrary, that, in the performative force that animates these spectacles, the language of the law and the language of photography are violently instated.

Tagg 2009:xxvi

For Tagg the camera is a weapon that is violently instrumentalized. Geoffrey Batchen, historian of photography, is critical of Tagg's view of photography as a: 'convenient conduit that enables these more or less powerless subjects to be represented by forces of modern oppression as objects of knowledge, analysis and control' (Batchen 1999:7). He follows instead Foucault's idea that power flows rather than oppresses from the top down.

Power must be seen as something that circulates, or rather as something which only functions in the form of a chain. It is never localised here or there, never in anybody's hands ... In other words, individuals are vehicles of power not its point of application.

Foucault 1980:98

Batchen prefers to see 'photography *as* power' (op cit 1999:169). The camera is often caught up in networks of power; it and the photographs are part of the flow. The presence of the camera can be a form of self-protection or resistance but it can also become a reason in itself to repress. Confiscation of cameras prevents photographs from being taken limiting the freedom of what is seen - in other words: censorship.¹⁸⁰

Like Berger, Butler considers photographs capable of extending an event outwards. In Butler's view it is only 'live streaming' that truly represents what is happening on the street: 'extending the scene' without interference from editorial bias or state intervention.

¹⁸⁰ There are many films of police brutality posted on YouTube in which officers attempt to stop filming (see Schneider 2015:229). Some private public places such as Paternoster Square and Granary Square prohibit filming or photography which could be seen as a pre-emptive form of censorship.

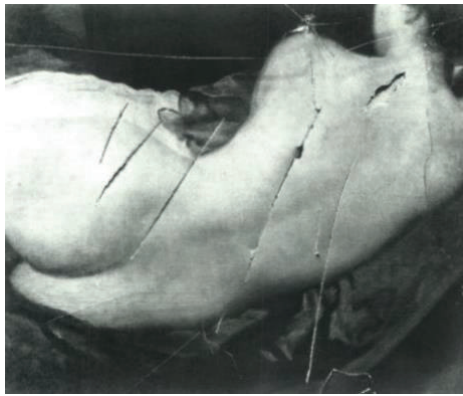


Figure 28 Diego Velázquez, *Detail of Rokeby Venus*, 1651 slashed in 1914

Figure 29 Criminal Record Office, Surveillance Photograph of Militant Suffragettes, silver print mounted onto identification sheet, 1914

Richardson's actions can be seen in wider feminist terms as an act against the male gaze which objectifies the naked female body. Arguably the act of slashing the canvas added a meaning to the painting of a nude woman that had not been there before. The iconoclasm, represented by the damaged canvas, led to the painting becoming symbolic of the suffragettes' cause. The slashes in the painting could be seen as destroying its beauty but also unsettling the viewer. As Mitchell argues: 'iconoclasm is more than just the destruction of images; it is a "creative destruction", in which a secondary image of defacement ... is created' (Mitchell 2005:18). The destruction or subversion of images or statues is still a valuable method for protesters, whether in the public art gallery or the public square. The secondary image that is created by destruction may pull the viewer towards forming different meanings about the original.¹⁷⁹ Photographs pass through similar paths, their meaning pulled upon by different forces, as can be seen in figure 29: the carefully posed society portrait can become a police mugshot. The same photograph may subvert but also surveil at the same time and therefore must always be treated with caution (Berger (1967)2013:21).

When photographs are taken of controversial events, whether of Brian Haw or Ada Wright, whose protests were forcefully countered by the police, the camera and the photograph take on a politically charged, active social role. The camera can become

¹⁷⁹ Neade discusses reactions to the secondary image of the *Rokeby Venus* being used by art critic Tom Philips to denigrate feminist interpretations of the nude (Neade 1992:27).

Surveillance and subversion

The photograph of Ada Wright (figure 27) draws out the duplicitous nature of the photograph and the possible consequences that stem from her coming into public visibility. The photograph, from a contemporary perspective, questions Churchill's version of Peel's policing by consent. The camera's capability to surveil and identify lurks beneath the surface of the photograph of her prostrate body on the pavement. The photograph of Ada Wright on the front page of *The Mirror* shocked the public, turned her into a public figure and publicized her cause.

Photographs make people visible. This visibility can promote a cause but at the same time it can put those made visible at risk. Figure 29 shows an incongruent accumulation of photographs of women: some are society portraits, some taken surreptitiously by the police of the subject while in prison, others by journalists as the women were arrested, others under coercion. Reminiscent of the Paris Communards (see pg .31 footnote 26) these photographs became weapons against those depicted. This police flyer depicting suffragette activists was circulated to public art galleries after Mary Richardson defaced Diego Velázquez's *Rokeby Venus* (1651) in the National Gallery in 1914 (figure 28). Richardson justified her act as a protest against the arrest of Emmeline Pankhurst a few days before: 'I have tried to destroy the picture of the most beautiful woman in mythological history as a protest against the Government for destroying Mrs. Pankhurst, who is the most beautiful character in modern history' (NPG website). The flyer's purpose was to aid the identification of possible future assailants; the photographs became shields to protect paintings by 'the Great Masters' from their potential female iconoclasts.¹⁷⁸

¹⁷⁸ Richardson's action was not a one-off; there were many similar incidents. However, as art historian Lynda Neade explains, the attack on the *Rokeby Venus* captured the public imagination (Neade 1992:15).

carried, to the other side of Bridge-street. The horse and motor traffic there was not stopped, but was somewhat hindered.

The Times 19th November, 1910

This excerpt emphasises the importance of a physical presence in making a political point known, felt and seen. Hindering the traffic, for example, always draws attention to a cause. The Liberal Government of the time made an attempt to stop publication of the photograph, however *The Mirror* defied these attempts, placing the photograph on its front page (see Halkon 2015). The treatment of women on this day by the police can be laid at the door of one of Peel's successors in the role of Home Secretary: Winston Churchill. There is debate as to whether he directly ordered brutality rather than arrests to try and quell the protests that had been organised to try and sway Parliament to vote for the Women's Suffrage Bill, or if he merely failed to stop it (see Colmore 2008). However his approach to policing the suffragette's protest fits into a pattern of his militaristic suppression of public protest. He had ordered troops and London Metropolitan Police to put down protests by miners in Tonypandy, Wales only 10 days before (8th November 1910).¹⁷⁶ The photograph of Ada Wright (figure 27) on the pavement, covering her face with her hands, was used and interpreted in many different ways. To me she appears vulnerable, she cannot be easily identified, the policemen's role is ambiguous, and the boy who seems to be smiling in the background adds a strange note. The fact that Churchill's statue has prime position, yet Ada Wright and others remain obscure only adds to the feeling of male dominance of the Square.¹⁷⁷

The dialogue between elements in the Square depicted in the photograph begins to open up other discussions and themes. The correspondence between the photographs' capability to both surveil and subvert, the contrast between virtual and actual, staged and real, viewer and viewed all stem from this one photograph.

¹⁷⁶ The facts are disputed as to who gave the orders to send in troops. Nevertheless Churchill's favoured method of control in these situations seems to have been a show of force, see Shelden (2013:234-5) and Herbert (1988:123).

¹⁷⁷ See pg. 271 for discussion on the addition of the statue of suffragist Millicent Fawcett.

active policing. Butler points to the physical presence of people on the street as representing innate freedom to express human needs. When the line is crossed and people are physically repressed, so are those freedoms: 'to attack the body is to attack the right itself, since the right is precisely what is exercised by the body on the street' (Butler 2011). Butler's account describes what Haw lived out physically and visibly in the Square. The Square has a history of skirmishes between the police and those seeking political change through public protest. Arguably photographs of such confrontations have redrawn the line in the public perception of what acceptable policing is. Many of these photographs can be found easily online, and the history surrounding them unravels further convolutions of the narrative of the Square.



Figure 27 Anon (*Daily Mirror*), Ada Wright on Black Friday, 1910

One of the earliest protest photographs that I came across on my initial Google search was taken on 18th November 1910 - a day which came to be known as Black Friday. It depicts suffragette Ada Wright lying on the floor covering her face, surrounded by a group of men including two policemen (figure 27). The situation in which a *Daily Mirror* reporter took the photograph is described by *The Times* the following day.

Meanwhile, the police in front of the gate at the corner of Parliament-street and Bridge-street were kept busy repelling the raiders, some of whom came up smiling every time to the attack, while a few scolded like viragoes and most were simply stolid. They were in every case seized and pushed, sometimes

also part of the event. The ethos that ‘the public are the police’ puts policing into the hands of all. Yet the reality of police overstepping their own rules or even being encouraged to ‘crack down’ on protesters forms another fine line which becomes palpable in this photograph: The balance of when to enforce the law and how.

The right to protest and question laws is often cited as being at the core of western democracy. It is enshrined in Article 11 of the European Convention on Human Rights.¹⁷⁴ However, public questioning of policies often transgresses local laws and oversteps boundaries. In Haw’s case his protest caused restrictive changes in the law: camping equipment is now banned, pedestrian flows were changed. Haw’s recourse to the legal system however allowed him freedom to remain in the Square. The persistence of individual bodies in particular places can change opinions about the laws of public freedom and their enforcement by drawing attention to the right to protest. Protesters question the democratic rhetoric of ‘public places’.¹⁷⁵

Habermas describes a situation in which what he calls ‘actors in civil society ... can assume a surprisingly active and momentous role’. Their chance to affect the dominant political sphere only occurs ‘at the critical moments of accelerated history,’ which is when ‘these actors get the chance to reverse the normal circuits of communication in the political system and the public sphere’ (Habermas 1996:380). Arguably Haw changed the establishment and public narrative of the Square for a while. He embodied the freedom to resist a foreign policy which was initiated on the rationale that Iraq posed an immediate threat to British security.

The clash between the positive use of the word freedom and its relationship to law, law enforcement and security is regularly played out in the public realm, whether carried out through passive aggressive street furniture, acts of transgression or

¹⁷⁴ Article 11 – Freedom of assembly and association

1. Everyone has the right to freedom of peaceful assembly and to freedom of association with others, including the right to form and to join trade unions for the protection of his interests.
2. No restrictions shall be placed on the exercise of these rights other than such as are prescribed by law and are necessary in a democratic society in the interests of national security or public safety, for the prevention of disorder or crime, for the protection of health or morals or for the protection of the rights and freedoms of others. This article shall not prevent the imposition of lawful restrictions on the exercise of these rights by members of the armed forces, of the police or of the administration of the State.

¹⁷⁵ The effect Haw’s protest had can also be seen in the reaction against the *Police Reform and Social Responsibility Act 2011*. Civil rights advocacy group Liberty expressed their concerns surrounding the effect of the bill on freedom of speech and protest that ‘the expansive and ill-defined restrictions’ (Liberty 2011) would have in Parliament Square.

constant scrutiny by the police. Various attempts to evict him are well documented and stand in stark contrast to this placid scene. The photogenic and powerful nature of those scenes of discord are distant from the calm barefooted tea drinkers, yet for me, the police's absence from this particular photograph recalls the more violent photographs.

Just outside of the frame of this passive protest photograph is the statue of former Prime Minister Robert Peel. Although not physically visible, his ideas are present as a tension within the photograph. As Berger states, photographs open up possibilities to envisage what might occur after the photograph has been taken. Possible futures can be imagined based on what is known through other photographs and events. The scene contains no police, no visible attempt to enforce the bylaws, to confiscate the tent or physically move the protesters on but the potential is there. Peel's ideal of how the policing of a country should work adds another layer to the social interactions at work in this place.¹⁷³ At the core of these principals, conceived when Peel was Home Secretary in 1829, was policing by consent:

To maintain at all times a relationship with the public that gives reality to the historic tradition that the police are the public and that the public are the police, the police being only members of the public who are paid to give full-time attention to duties which are incumbent on every citizen in the interests of community welfare and existence.

Peelian principles handed to the Metropolitan Police 1829

Peel wrote into British law what is already contained within the etymology of the word police, deriving from policy, but also from 'politia', meaning the body of citizens, and 'polis', the city. 'Police' read in this way encompasses people, law and urban place; the will of citizens as a whole and the laws of the city set by politicians. The link between the three - law, place and people - is contained within this photograph (figure 25). It depicts the right of free speech in a public place but also the need to control such protests for the perceived benefit of the mass population. Moreover it also depicts the right of the people to police the actions of the government through freedom of public assembly. The camera bears witness but is

¹⁷³ As well as serving two stints as Home Secretary, Peel was Prime Minister between 1834–1835 and 1841–1846.

can be seen as a precursor of the Occupy Movement. As the name suggests, the Occupy Movement's pitching of tents changes urban public places dominated by state or commercial interests into ones where people live. The act of camping and living in public drew directs attention to the lack of wealth and privilege of the 99%.¹⁶⁸ Massey described the protesters' tents pitched in protest in the middle of the city as making a poignant contrast to the solidity of St Paul's and the corporate buildings in Paternoster Square (Massey 2013).¹⁶⁹ A contrast that had already been seen as protesters set up camp near Wall Street in New York's Zuccotti Park earlier in 2011.¹⁷⁰ Through these actions places can be transformed; they are restaged highlighting the individual and their personal private needs.¹⁷¹ The tent wall offers only the thinnest of barriers between private and public place. The fragility of the tent and the basic conditions lived out in public animates the government buildings and alters their meaning, drawing attention to the precarity of many individuals.¹⁷² At the time this photograph was taken and shared, the act of pitching a tent was illegal. A by-law had been passed to deter further attempts to re-occupy the Square. So the act of erecting even this imitation of a tent was deliberately provocative.

Bare feet and statues

The bare footed protesters seem vulnerable to me in this photograph (figure 25). The individuals pit themselves against the power of the establishment embodied by stone and bronze in the Square. They await eviction with a thermos of tea, expectant that their act of provocation will cause a reaction, like Haw who was subject to

¹⁶⁸ 'We are the 99%' was one of the slogans of the Occupy Movement, drawing attention to the 1% who hold wealth.

¹⁶⁹ Occupy protesters first attempted to pitch tents in Paternoster Square opposite the London Stock Exchange in October 2011. However because this is a tightly controlled, privately owned public place to avoid eviction the protesters moved next to St Paul's where they stayed until February 2012.

¹⁷⁰ Formerly called Liberty Park Plaza, the area was severely damaged during the 9/11 attacks and eventually reopened and was renamed after the current owner John Zuccotti in 2006. In a mirror image of London, protesters in New York chose Zuccotti Park precisely because its status as a privately owned public place meant it was subject to different bylaws than public parks which have a dusk curfew. Zuccotti Park was the first of many Occupy camps, St Paul's and Finsbury Square being the most notable in London.

¹⁷¹ Local workers brought food to the protesters and offered warmth and shower facilities in their places of work (see Kadet 2011).

¹⁷² Precarity could be defined as the position of individuals living a precarious existence monetarily, socially and psychologically. Professor of development studies Guy Standing delineates a 'global thinning of democracy' (Standing 2012) and makes the link between precarity, globalisation and the Occupy Movement.